CHAPTER 7

Transition Stage of a Group

Introduction
Characteristics of the Transition Stage
Group Members Who Pose a Challenge for Leaders
Dealing With Defensive Behavior Therapeutically
Dealing With Avoidance by the Whole Group
Dealing With Transference and Countertransference
Coleader Issues at the Transition Stage
Points to Remember
Exercises
Guide to Groups in Action: Evolution and Challenges DVD and Workbook



CHAPTER LEARNING OBJECTIVES

1. Describe the dynamics associated with group process and development (CACREP, 2016, Standard B)
2. Identify and understand key characteristics of a group during the transition stage
3. Explore ways of effectively dealing with defensiveness and reluctant behaviors
4. Critically evaluate the notion of resistance
5. Understand common fears and anxiety of members
6. Gain a deeper appreciation for ways to explore conflict in a group
7. Differentiate between effective and ineffective styles of confrontation
8. Explore ways to therapeutically address problematic behaviors
9. Understand the dynamics of members' problematic behavior
10. Describe behaviors indicating avoidance by the whole group
11. Understand the dynamics of transference and countertransference in a group
12. Identify coleadership issues during the transition stage

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You are coleading a weekly therapy group in a community agency and find you are having increasing difficulties working with one of the members. You realize that it is difficult for you to like him because he reminds you of someone from your past. In addition to your own countertransference, several members seem very defensive with you and your coleader. They often collude with each other when you attempt to challenge them. In your last group meeting, one of the members openly confronted you and asked, "How can you help me if you have never walked in my shoes?" After the session, you and your coleader process the group.

- In what ways are these issues normative or common to the transition stage of a group? How will you work with your countertransference issues?
- What strategies will you and your coleader use to address the "defensiveness" of group members?
- How did you react to the member's direct challenge to you?
- In what ways can you therapeutically respond to his question?
- What feelings do you think underlie his question to you?

LO1

Introduction

Before groups progress to a level of deeper work, which we refer to as the working stage, they typically experience a transitional phase. If group members are not willing to disclose the ways in which they are struggling with both themselves and one another, they are not able to move forward and develop the trust necessary for deeper work. What the members and leaders do during this transitional period often will determine whether or not a group develops a cohesive community that allows members to engage in meaningful interpersonal exploration. A group's ability to move forward is dependent on the ability and willingness of both members and leaders to work with whatever emerges in the here and now.

The transition stage of a group is particularly challenging for group leaders, and it is a difficult time for members as well. During this phase, groups are often characterized by anxiety, defensiveness, guardedness, ambivalence, resistance, a range of control issues, intermember conflicts, challenges to the leader, and various patterns of problematic behaviors. These difficulties are a normal part of the unfolding process of a group, and remaining curious about members' defensive behavior will serve you better than reacting critically. To avoid entrenching what appears to be uncooperative behavior, it can be useful to shift your attitude and acknowledge that certain behaviors may be the result of members' fear, confusion, and cautiousness. For instance, if you can understand a reluctant member's behavior as symptomatic of being scared or another member's silence as indicative of his lack of knowledge regarding how to best participate in a group, you will have a more positive attitude toward these behaviors. By changing the label "resistant" to more descriptive and nonjudgmental terminology, it is likely that you will change your attitude toward members who represent a challenge for you.

As you change the lens by which you perceive members' behaviors, it will be easier to adopt an understanding attitude and to encourage members to explore

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ways they are reluctant and self-protective. It is essential to remain nondefensive and help members express their legitimate feelings about not wanting to trust you or other members. By viewing members' behavior in this manner, you are also more likely to access the cultural dimensions associated with certain signs of reluctant behaviors. For example, a member who is silent, one who defers to authority, or one who gives a lot of advice may be doing so due to cultural norms rather than purposefully exhibiting difficult behaviors. Assist these members in giving voice to their past and present experiences and acknowledge their feelings before interpreting their behavior as based on a lack of trust in you as a leader or of other members. When people feel heard and acknowledged, they may be more open to change.

Some of the most productive work in the life of a group takes place during this time of transition. This is a time in the group in which both members and leaders are learning about each other's capacity and style for change. Members may learn new ways of dealing with challenges, such as staying with a conflict situation rather than avoiding it. As members continue talking, they may eventually reach a resolution and a deepening of the relationship. The manner in which members display their defensive behavior is also a window into their ego strength. It is useful for leaders to observe and file away this information, which later may be brought to bear on interventions during the working stage.

In assisting a group to meet the tasks of the transition stage, you need to have a clear understanding of the characteristics and dynamics of a group during this phase of development. Be particularly mindful of your own reactions, especially the tendency to assume total responsibility for whatever is happening in the group—or of putting full responsibility on the members. In this chapter we deal with the typical characteristics of a group during the transition stage and suggest interventions for dealing with problems that may occur at this stage.

LO2

Characteristics of the Transition Stage

Anxiety and defensiveness underlies much of members' behavior in the transitional phase. To get beyond this phase, members must be able to deal effectively with defensiveness. A leader's task is to help members identify and confront their fears and to work through possible conflict and control issues. The goal of this stage is to create a safe and trusting climate that encourages members to take risks. Some members may lack understanding or experience in participating in groups, and their struggle to learn new behavior patterns should not be labeled as defensive. People bring their typical ways of communicating to a group, and they are often open to learning more effective ways of expressing themselves.

Establishing Trust

Establishing trust is a central task of the initial phase in the evolution of a group, but members may still be wondering if the group is a safe place for them during the transition phase. Considerable hesitation and observing both the other members and the leader are common. As a climate of trust is gradually created,

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members can express their reactions without fear of censure or of being judged. Often one member's willingness to take the risk to disclose a concern or fear will lead others to do the same. These disclosures are a turning point in establishing a greater degree of trust.

When trust is high, members are actively involved in the activities in the group: making themselves known to others in personal ways, taking risks both in the group and out of group, focusing on themselves and not on others, actively working in the group on meaningful personal issues, disclosing persistent feelings such as lack of trust, and supporting and challenging others in the group.

By contrast, here are some clear signs that trust is lacking:

- Members will not initiate work.
- Members frequently show up late, leave early, or miss sessions.
- Members are reluctant to participate due to their fear of being confronted.
- Members keep their reactions to themselves or express them in indirect ways.
- Members take refuge in storytelling.
- Members are excessively quiet.
- Members put more energy into helping others or giving others advice than into sharing their own personal concerns.
- Members demand that group leaders take charge; they may say "Tell us what to do."
- Some members may say they have problems too big for the group; others may say they have no problems.
- Members avoid dealing openly with conflict and may not even acknowledge it.
- Members may have split into subgroups.
- Members may keep their agenda hidden from leaders or other members.

When trust is lacking, members are still checking out what is happening in the room, yet they may be doing so quietly, which makes it difficult to explore what is occurring within the group. Some members may be testing the leader, especially those who have had negative experiences with authority figures. This is not uncommon for individuals who have experienced oppression and who are checking to see whether the leader, or other members, may be prejudiced in some way. It may be helpful to encourage members to make this testing process explicit by putting words to what they are seeing and concluding. Other members may make judgmental statements, which have the effect of inhibiting open participation. We find over and over that many of the problems arising in a group are not due to the feelings and thoughts people *do* express but to those reactions they *do not* express. Our central leadership task at the transition stage is to encourage members to say aloud what they are thinking and feeling about what is happening within the group. We often provide prompts, asking members to complete sentences like these: "One thing I am afraid to say in this group is . . ." "If you really knew me, you would . . ." "It is difficult for me to trust people because . . .".

Mistrust is normal in the beginning stages of a group. If leaders are able to acknowledge that members have different styles of building trust and can normalize this, it may encourage members to begin talking about their past and current experiences with building and maintaining trust in relationships. Each member

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must actively work to open him- or herself to trusting others and to addressing the issues that get in the way of doing so.

In rare instances, a scripted exercise may be useful to get members to begin to open up and take some risks with one another. In a group I (Cindy) led, members were well aware of the silence and lack of participation in the room. Using an exercise I adapted from my colleague Denny Ollerman, I asked if they were willing to try something that involved a significant amount of risk. I participated in the activity myself as a way of modeling my own willingness to be vulnerable and to take a risk within the group. By going first I set a tone for the members. Each person was asked to stand in front of three different members and complete the following sentence: "Something I don't want you to know about me is . . ." For example, one member might say, "Something I don't want you to know about me is, I hate my body," and then she may say to another member, "Something I don't want you to know about me is, I don't trust men." After everyone had taken turns completing the sentence three times, an abundance of topics were ready to be discussed and reactions to be shared. This type of exercise should be done with care, and leaders need to be skilled at helping members process their feelings as a result of participating in such vulnerable and powerful ways.

Using dyads is another way of infusing untapped energy into a quiet or reserved group. A small group I (Cindy) coled was characterized by low energy, and I wanted to shift the energy in the room. I decided to have the members break into dyads and take turns answering two prompts: "How are you experiencing me?" and "Something that keeps me from feeling close to you is . . ." This exercise led to some very honest and insightful conversations, and the energy level of the whole group was heightened. At the next session, members seemed more willing to share on deeper levels and to take risks with one another that they previously had not been willing to take.

Defensiveness and Reluctant Behavior

LO3

Participants are often torn between wanting to be safe and wanting to risk. It makes sense for members to proceed with caution. Members will not begin intensive work unless there is a climate of safety. Both the leader and members must understand the meaning of defensive or cautious behavior. It is essential that leaders be respectful and patient of members' processes and defenses.

From a psychoanalytic perspective, resistance is defined as the individual's reluctance to bring into conscious awareness threatening material that has been previously repressed or denied. It also can be viewed as anything that prevents members from dealing with unconscious material. From a broader perspective, resistance can be viewed as behavior that keeps us from exploring personal conflicts or painful feelings. Resistance is one way we attempt to protect ourselves from anxiety.

Members will not begin intensive work unless there is a climate of safety.

Respecting a member's defensiveness means the leader does not chastise a reluctant person but explores the source of his or her hesitation. Members often have realistic reasons for their reluctance. For example, one woman was

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typically quiet during group and would speak only when others addressed her. When the group leader pointed this out, she said that she felt embarrassed to speak because of her accent. She was convinced that she did not speak English well enough to be understood; this kept her silent. Although she wanted to bring up this subject, the thought of being the center of attention was so anxiety-provoking for her that she said as little as possible. To dismiss this client as *resistant* would show a lack of respect for her genuine reluctance and could serve to discount her very real and painful experiences with discrimination as a bilingual person.

As a bilingual person, I (Marianne) was very self-conscious speaking English and worried about using correct grammar. I was even more self-conscious around fellow Germans who had a better command of English than I did. When conducting a group in Korea with Korean nationals, I found that this feeling is widespread. Inquiring about their hesitation to speak up in group during several sessions, some members said they were rehearsing in their head how to express themselves in English without making grammatical mistakes. Some shared that they would reflect on how they expressed themselves in English when outside the group and that they practiced what they wanted to say for an upcoming session. Being in an all-Korean group with members who had varying degrees of command of the English language increased their anxiety about speaking "correctly." Exploring their reasons for not speaking up gave new meaning to their lack of participation.

Clients' reluctance to express themselves sometimes represents a coping strategy that at one time served an adaptive function but that no longer serves a useful purpose. Leaders can assist members in reframing their resistance. If you are able to understand their hesitation, members may come to realize and appreciate that a particular coping strategy was the best possible response to a difficult situation earlier in life but that it is no longer effective. Resistance is a natural part of the therapeutic process and can lead to productive exploration in the group; it needs to be acknowledged, talked about, and understood.

The most therapeutic way to deal with difficult behaviors is for leaders to simply describe to members what they are observing and let members know how they are affected by what they see and hear. This approach is an invitation for members to determine if what they are doing is working for them. If leaders do not respect members' defenses against anxiety, they are not respecting the members themselves. For example, Melody reveals some painful material and then suddenly stops and says that she doesn't want to go on. In respecting Melody's reluctance, the leader asks her what is stopping her rather than pushing her to continue dealing with her pain. Melody indicates that she is afraid of losing people's respect. The issue now becomes her lack of trust in the group rather than a painful personal problem. If the leader proceeds in this manner, Melody is more likely to eventually talk openly about personal matters. If the leader ignores Melody's initial hesitation by pushing her to open up, she is more likely to close up and not talk. However, if the leader does not inquire about the meaning of her reluctance, she might close off useful avenues of self-exploration.

Sometimes members' hesitations are the result of factors such as an unqualified leader, an aggressive and uncaring leadership style, or a failure to prepare members for participation in the group. One of the key tasks of leadership is to accurately appraise whether the source of difficulty is the members' fears or

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ineffective leadership. If you show a willingness to understand the context of the members' behavior, the likelihood of cooperation and risk-taking is increased.

Members of an involuntary group may exhibit a lack of cooperation through sarcasm and silence. This gives members some power in a situation in which they feel powerless. If you respond in a negative way to this behavior, you are likely to entrench this pattern. It is important not to respond with defensiveness when dealing with a client who does not want to participate.

Dwight: I don't want to be here! This group won't do me any good.

Leader [*in a nondefensive tone*]: So you don't want to be here. Do you know why you are here? From your perspective, why do you think you were asked to be here?

Dwight: They sent me, and I don't need this group. [*shrugs shoulders*] I don't have a choice.

Leader: It's difficult to do something you don't want to do. Tell me about other times when people tell you what to do. What is that like for you?

Dwight: I don't know what it's like. I just know I really don't have any choices.

Leader: I guess I could argue that everyone ultimately has a choice, but that won't get us anywhere. I know that other members have felt the same way you do about this group. Can we talk about how we dealt with it as a group?

It is important to follow the member's lead and *go with* his negative reaction rather than fighting it or taking it personally. Dwight's reluctance can be responded to in a variety of ways. Here are some intervention statements that may increase the odds that an involuntary member will become a voluntary participant:

- Many group members have felt the same way you do now. Maybe they could tell you what it was like for them.
- What do you know about counseling? Have you ever participated in a group?
- Why do you think you were sent here?
- What would the person who sent you here tell me about why you're here?
- How do you cope with having to do something you don't want to do?
- How would you like it to be? What can you do to get there?

If you understand the dynamics of a group member's negative reactions and do not respond defensively, the intensity of the problematic behavior is likely to diminish. As the recipient of this uncooperative behavior, you may feel personally rejected, but you cannot afford the luxury of feeling vulnerable to rejection. Process your reactions at a later time through self-reflection, supervision, or consultation.

A Critique of the Notion of Resistance

LO4

A number of writers in the psychotherapy field have challenged the traditional view of resistance and have reconceptualized the role of resistance in therapy. Erving Polster and Miriam Polster (1973), leading figures in Gestalt therapy, suggest that what often passes for resistance is not simply a barrier to therapy but is a "creative force for managing a difficult world" (p. 52). They assert that the idea of resistance is unnecessary and incompatible with Gestalt therapy (Polster & Polster, 1976). The problem associated with labeling a behavior as resistance is the

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implication that the behavior or trait is "alien" to the person and needs to be eliminated if the person is to function in healthy ways. By avoiding the use of the term *resistance*, the therapist avoids the assumption that the client is behaving inappropriately. Instead of trying to change a client's behavior or make something happen, the Polsters focus on what is actually happening in the present and explore this with the client.

Steve de Shazer (1984), one of the pioneers of solution-focused brief therapy, wrote about "The Death of Resistance." He believes the notion of client resistance attributes most of the blame for lack of progress to the client while allowing the practitioner to avoid responsibility for what is happening in therapy. De Shazer assumes that clients are competent in figuring out what they want and need. It is the practitioner's responsibility to assist clients in identifying their competencies and using them to create satisfying lives. If the notion of client competence is accepted, then *client resistance* is better viewed as *practitioner resistance*. According to de Shazer, therapeutic impasses result from the therapist's failure to listen to and understand clients.

Like de Shazer, Bill O'Hanlon (2003) attributes client resistance to misunderstanding and inflexibility on the therapist's part. From O'Hanlon's perspective, what therapists call resistance often reflects genuine concerns on the part of clients. O'Hanlon's solution-oriented therapy challenges the basic belief of many therapists who assume that clients do not really want to change and are thus resistant to therapy. O'Hanlon and Weiner-Davis (2003) invite therapists to question their basic assumptions about clients and monitor the ways they use language in therapy. They also caution therapists not to focus on finding resistance, lest this becomes a self-fulfilling prophecy.

In writing about resistance in therapy from the perspective of narrative therapy, Winslade, Crocket, and Monk (1997) emphasize the therapeutic relationship. When therapy becomes difficult, they avoid placing the responsibility on the client, for doing so results in blaming the client for what is happening in the therapeutic relationship. Instead, Winslade and colleagues pay close attention to the conversations with their clients to discover possible reasons for the difficulty in therapy.

Motivational interviewing reframes resistance as a healthy response and emphasizes reflective listening, which is a way for practitioners to better understand the subjective world of clients (Miller & Rollnick, 2013). Reluctance to change is viewed as a normal and expected part of the therapeutic process. Although individuals may see advantages to making life changes, they also have many concerns and fears about changing. People who seek therapy are often ambivalent about change, and their motivation may ebb and flow during the course of therapy. A key goal of motivational interviewing is to increase internal motivation to change based on the values of the client. Those who practice motivational interviewing assume a respectful view of resistance and work therapeutically with any reluctance or ambivalence on the part of clients. When clients are slow to change, it may be assumed that they have both compelling reasons to remain as they are as well as having reasons to change.

Group practitioners with a cognitive behavioral orientation tend to reframe the concept of resistance so that group members are not blamed. Attention is given

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to assessment and then designing a treatment plan that is customized to the needs of the members (Beck, 2005, 2011). These group counselors emphasize a therapeutic partnership with group members so that goals are agreed upon by both the members and the leader. Through this collaborative style, cooperation is more likely to increase.

In summary, Gestalt therapy, solution-focused therapy, narrative therapy, motivational interviewing, and cognitive behavior therapy, are therapeutic approaches that question the validity and usefulness of the way resistance is typically used. Each of these therapeutic models reconceptualizes the phenomenon of resistance by encouraging therapists to pay attention to what is transpiring in the present context of the therapeutic relationship and in the group itself. We try to think of ways to describe to members what we are observing rather than suggesting they are resisting, and we ask members to consider whether the ways they are behaving are helping or hindering them in getting what they want. By approaching member resistance with respect, interest, and understanding, defensive behavior is likely to decrease.

Learning in Action

Reflection on Intention

The way we interpret a person's action directly affects the way we respond. If someone lies to you, you have a right to feel hurt or angry. However, if you want to move past those feelings, look for the reasons the person may have lied. Was the person afraid to disappoint you? Was the person worried about being rejected? Would you respond differently to someone who lied to you versus someone who was afraid? How might your interventions differ if you look at the interaction from a different perspective?

We judge our own behaviors with more understanding than we do the behaviors of others. For example, if you are changing lanes on the freeway and don't see the car next to you, you know that your actions were unintentional. But the person whose car you cut off on the road may assume you did so intentionally and be angry. Think of an action by someone close to you that bothered you. What did you feel when this occurred? What was your initial reaction to that person? How did you judge this individual's behavior? Now look at the same action but describe it in a less defensive way. This is often difficult to do in our personal lives, but it is a helpful skill when working with clients who exhibit problematic behavior in a group.

Common Fears and Anxieties Experienced by Members LO5

When group members keep their fears to themselves, they may be expressed through a variety of avoidant behaviors. Although members cannot be forced to discuss their fears, you can invite them to recognize that they may be experiencing something that is common to many members. It is almost always helpful to acknowledge the members' feelings first, before pushing them to move through their fears or too hastily reassuring members that their fears will not be realized in this group experience. Leaders cannot promise members that their willingness to take risks in a group will end positively, but a therapeutic group is one of the best places for members to have new experiences in relating to others. It can result in healing old wounds and fears from past or present relationships. As members

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use the group as a safe place to explore their fears, they learn new ways to address their concerns both in the group and in their everyday lives with others.

During the transition stage, anxiety is high within individuals and within the group as a whole. If members are willing to voice their anxious thoughts, these feelings can be explored and more fully understood. For example, Christie expresses internal concerns: "I'm really afraid to go further for fear of what I'll find out." Sunny is more anxious about what others are thinking: "I'm afraid to speak up in here because some people seem judgmental." These concerns may be projections on the part of Christie and Sunny, but their willingness to express their feelings is pivotal in moving from a transition to a working stage in the group. As participants come to more fully trust one another and the leader, they are increasingly able to share their concerns. This openness lessens the anxiety group members have about letting others see them as they are.

Members may fear exposing their pain, sounding trite, being overcome by intense emotions, being misunderstood, being rejected, or not knowing what is expected. Brief descriptions of common fears and anxieties manifested during the transition stage are presented next along with possible interventions that might be helpful to members. It can be useful to share some of the common fears and concerns with group members in an effort to normalize what they may be feeling and to help establish a safe environment in which they can express their own fears with the group.

The Fear of Self-Disclosure Members often fear self-disclosure, thinking that they will be pressured to open up before they are ready. It helps to reinforce emphatically to members that they can make themselves known to others and at the same time retain their privacy. Consider this example: "I can't imagine myself talking about my parents in the negative ways that others are doing in here," Nicole said. "If I were to talk this way about my parents, I would be overcome with shame and disloyalty." Because the leader is aware of certain cultural values that Nicole holds, he lets her know that he respects her decision. He did not push her to do something that she would later regret. But he did encourage her to think of ways she could participate in the group that would be meaningful to her. There is a delicate balance between reluctance because of cultural injunctions and cautiousness in moving into frightening territory. As we explained in Chapter 5, it is the choice of members to determine *what* and *how* much they share. When they recognize that they control what they choose to tell others about themselves, participants tend to be less fearful of self-disclosure.

The Fear of Being Exposed and Vulnerable Some members may hesitate to participate fully out of a desire to avoid feeling vulnerable. Having been shamed, attacked, blamed, or ridiculed for expressing themselves to others in their everyday relationships, these members may feel it is too risky to share themselves in personal ways. It is important for the leader to help members express their past experiences while also inviting them to have a new and perhaps healthier experience with being vulnerable in the group. For example, Marisa had a prior negative experience in attempting to express her feelings in her family. She was asked what she needed from the leader and other group members in order to feel safe. Others

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then responded to her disclosure. The leader asked Marisa to talk about how safe it felt for her to listen to the responses of both the leader and group members. In the group, she learned that once her feelings were recognized and accepted her sense of safety increased. In this case, the group leader helped Marisa to overcome her fear by allowing her to base her current level of exposure on what was happening in the room rather what had happened to her in her family.

The Fear of Rejection We sometimes hear participants say that they are reluctant to get involved with others in the group because of the fear of rejection. Stephen repeatedly spoke of his fears that people would not want anything to do with him. He had erected walls to protect himself from the pain of rejection, and he made the assumption that the group would turn against him if he did reveal himself. The leader asked, "Are you willing to look around the room and see if you feel that every person in this room would reject you?" Stephen took some time to look around the room at the 10 group members: he was convinced that 4 of them would reject him, and he was not sure of 2 of them. Stephen agreed to continue working and was asked if he was willing to "own" his projections by addressing the following sentence to those he thought might reject him: "I'm afraid that you will reject me because. . . ." He also talked to the people he felt were more accepting and explained why he thought differently about them. When Stephen was finished, others reacted to him in a sensitive way and explained why they were afraid of him or found it difficult to get close to him. Through this exploration, Stephen learned about his part in creating a sense of rejection. With exercises like these, leaders must intervene if members become defensive and want to respond, thus interrupting the flow of Stephen's work. It is important that members learn that what Stephen is saying is more about him than about them. The work is about dealing with Stephen's projections and his perception of being rejected rather than establishing, at this moment, whether members are rejecting him or not.

The Fear of Being Misunderstood or Judged For some people, the fear of being judged or misunderstood is a very real barrier to letting themselves be known in a group. This can be especially difficult for members who have experienced oppression or discrimination in various forms. It is common in our work to hear members from various cultural groups share painful experiences of being labeled or judged for who they are and feeling as if they have to defend themselves and others from their cultural group. Some members have early memories of being in groups (typically in school settings) in which they were ridiculed and discriminated against both overtly and covertly for being "different." For these people, it is crucial that the leader understands and respects the members' history and does not move too quickly to reassure them that this group will be different. By helping members express their previous pain around being misunderstood and judged, the leader can provide tools for exploring new ways of taking risks that will result in more positive outcomes.

The Fear of Being Challenged or Singled Out Some members may stay silent or hidden in group as a way of avoiding the fear of being challenged by group leaders or other members. Some people have extreme difficulty with conflict and

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may be fearful of having attention given to them in the group. They may be engaging in *all or nothing* thinking, believing that if "called upon" it would be negative. Whether this fear is due to temperament, cultural factors, or life experiences, leaders can help reluctant members find ways of participating in the group and engaging with others that do not paralyze them with fear. By helping these members see that they are cheating themselves and others of potentially rich encounters by remaining invisible, leaders may help fearful members begin to take steps toward making themselves seen.

The Fear of Losing Control Marin expressed her fear that she might open up some potentially painful areas and be left even more vulnerable. She was anxious about "going too deep" as she put it. She wondered, "Will I be able to stand the pain? Maybe it would be best if things were just left as they are. If I started crying, I might never stop! Even though I might get support in the group, what will I do when group is over?" The leader responded, "I'm sure you've been alone and have found it painful. What do you normally do when this happens?" Marin replied, "I lock myself in the room, I don't talk to anyone, and I just cry by myself and then get depressed." The leader asked Marin to pick two or three people in the room that she thought would be most able to understand her pain and tell them, while looking at them, about some of the distress in her life. As she did this, she would be likely to discover the difference between isolating herself in pain and sharing it with others and experiencing their support. She could also come to the realization that she did not have to deal with her pain alone, unless she chose to do so. She could be challenged to identify a few people in the group and in her outside life whom she could reach out to in time of need.

Some Other Fears A variety of other fears are often expressed by members:

- I'm concerned about seeing these people out of group and what they will think of me.
- I'm afraid I will be talked about outside of group.
- I'm afraid I'll get too dependent on the group and rely too much on others to solve my problems.
- If I get angry, I'm afraid I'll lose control and hurt somebody.
- I worry that once I am open I might not be able to close up again.
- I'm uncomfortable with physical contact, and I'm afraid that I'll be expected to hug others when I don't want to.
- I'm worried that I'll take too much group time by talking about my problems, that I'll bore people.
- I'm afraid I'll get close to people here and then never see them again when the group ends.

Though it is not realistic to expect that all these fears can be eliminated, we do think members can be encouraged to face these fears by talking about them. Through what you model as a leader, you can help create a trusting climate in which members will feel free enough to test their fears and discriminate between realistic and unrealistic fears. If members decide to talk about their fears and if this decision is made relatively early in a group, a good foundation of trust is created

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that will enable them to deal constructively with other personal concerns as the group evolves.

Journal Prompts

It can be helpful to reflect on your own fears as a way of reminding yourself of how vulnerable members can sometimes feel. It is easy to hide behind the safety of a leadership role and forget to connect to the parts of yourself that may be uncomfortable to look at but that increase your compassion and empathy.

1. What is an example of one fear that you have experienced in a group?
2. How has this fear affected your participation in a group?
3. How could you challenge this fear?

Struggles With Control

Maintaining a sense of control is a common theme at the transition stage. Some characteristic group behaviors include discussions about the division of responsibility and decision-making procedures. Participants' main anxieties in the transition phase relate to having too much or too little responsibility. To deal constructively with these issues, members must bring them to the surface and talk about them. If the here-and-now problems are ignored, the group will be inhibited by the hidden agenda.

The leader's task is to help members understand that their struggle to maintain control may be a way of protecting themselves from doing more in-depth work. For example, Heather may say, "No matter what I say or do, it never seems to be the right thing. Why can't I just do it my way?" The leader might respond, "I'm not looking at what you're doing in terms of right or wrong. I'm more concerned that what you do will help you achieve the goals you set for yourself. I've noticed that you seem to avoid talking about difficult areas in your life." Another intervention would be to ask Heather, "How would you like to use your time in this group?" Or the leader might say, "Tell me more about what has been helpful to you in this group and what has not."

Conflict

LO6

Conflict is a difficult subject for some people to deal with, both in groups and in daily living. There is an assumption that conflict is a sign of something intrinsically wrong and that it should be avoided at all costs. Within a group, the leader and the members sometimes want to avoid conflict rather than spending the time and effort necessary to work through it, but this may interfere with the work of the group. Conflict can be expected in all relationships; it is frequently the avoidance of conflict that is problematic. Unexplored conflict is typically expressed in defensive behavior, indirectness, and a general lack of trust. Groups offer an ideal environment for learning to deal with conflict effectively. During any stage of a group's

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development, but especially during the early phase, it is crucial that conflict be acknowledged and managed effectively so that the level of trust will increase. A primary task of leaders is to teach members the value of working through conflicts in a constructive way.

Jennifer expressed a conflict within one group: "Some people in here never say anything." Houston immediately replied, defensively, "Not everybody has to be as talkative as you." Leticia joined in, sarcastically, "Well, Jennifer, you talk so much you don't give me a chance to participate!" Alejandro's contribution was, "I wish you would stop this arguing. This isn't getting us anywhere." Ineffective interventions by the leader are: "I agree with you, Alejandro. Why don't we just try to get along? Or "Jennifer, you're right. There are people in here who say very little. I wish they would take as many risks as you do!" Such remarks increase members' defensiveness.

The emerging conflict was dealt with constructively when the leader took the approach of exploring the underlying dynamics of what had been said and what was *not* being said: "I agree with you, Alejandro, that right now we are struggling, but I don't want people to stop talking because we need to know what all this means." Turning to Jennifer, the leader asked: "How are you affected by all these reactions? Is there anyone in particular you want to hear from? How does it affect you when people don't say much? How would it be helpful if people talked more?"

Jennifer's original statement was a defensive and chastising remark to the group in general. The group reacted with understandable defensiveness. The leader addressed Jennifer's difficulty with the group and tried to get her to be more specific about how she was affected by people whom she saw as being silent. The conflict found resolution when she let people know that she was afraid that they were judging her when they said very little and that she was interested in how they perceived her. Chances are that this conflict would not have come about if Jennifer had said something like this to Leticia: "I notice that you're quiet, and I often wonder what you think of me. I'd like to hear from you." Such a statement would have reflected more accurately what was going on with Jennifer than did her punitive remark. It is important for the leader not to cut off the expression of conflict but to facilitate more direct and personal expression of feeling and thinking among the members.

Conflict may be created by not attending to the diversity issues that exist within a group. Some of the areas of diversity in a group that are potential sources of conflict and distrust include differences in age, gender, language, sexual orientation, socioeconomic status, power, privilege, disability, race, ethnicity, and educational attainment. Leaders need to be aware that people from different cultures may address conflict in different ways. What looks like conflict in one culture may be a normative interaction in another culture.

Regardless of their cultural background, members can have a difficult time dealing with conflict because of learned patterns in their family of origin. Some people come from families in which conflict meant that someone was hurt or there was a winner and a loser. These members may not have learned to deal with conflict as a part of healthy relationships. Individuals from privileged groups may find it difficult to understand the experience of those who are not privileged. For example, George, a White male, contends that he does not see himself as privileged

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in any way and that his life is completely the result of his hard work. George adamantly denies any privileges associated with his race or gender. Members of color and women often express frustration and sometimes anger at assertions like these, claiming that George (and others like him) shows either a lack of awareness or an unwillingness to examine his own privileged status. As in many of these cultural conflicts, the key is to be able to facilitate exploration of the topic and the emotions around it without judging or condemning members. This type of facilitation requires an understanding of complex multicultural issues and experience in group process.

As another example, consider a bicultural group member (Maria) who speaks with an accent. If Maria talks about her anxiety over people's reactions to her accent, and if others in the group who have not struggled with discrimination are unable to empathize with her concerns, she may be wounded in the group just as she has been so often in her everyday life. Maria is then unlikely to disclose other significant issues because she does not feel understood or safe. Any conflict that results from failing to understand and appreciate member differences must be openly addressed and worked through if a trusting climate is to be established. If this conflict is ignored, mistrust is bound to appear and the group's progress can be stalled.

Leaders need to balance what can feel like opposing sides with great care and attention, challenging members to hear the experience of other members while not shutting them down by the interaction. This does not mean that the interaction has to be polite or even comfortable. On the contrary, meaningful and authentic discussions of diversity often are carried out with some level of intensity and heightened emotion. Our task is to facilitate in a way that the emotions do not immobilize people from moving forward but motivate members to struggle through the interchange to gain greater self-awareness and a better understanding of the perspectives of others in relation to their diverse cultural contexts and lives.

Cohesion within a group typically increases after conflict is recognized and expressed in a healthy way. Stating what is keeping you cautious is one way of testing the freedom and trustworthiness of the group. During the transition stage participants continue to test whether this group is a safe place in which to disagree openly and whether they will be accepted in spite of the intensity of their feelings. When conflict is constructively discussed, members learn that their relationships are strong enough to withstand an honest level of challenge, which is what many people want to achieve in their outside relationships.

Reflect on your concerns about managing conflict when it emerges in a group you are leading:

- How confident are you that you can address conflict when it is aimed at you?
- Do you have the skills you need to deal effectively with conflict between or among group members?
- What steps can you take to improve your ability to assist members in dealing effectively with conflict that arises in a group?

Confrontation

LO7

If people want to take a deeper and more honest look at themselves, it is necessary that they be willing to risk expressing what is on their minds, even though

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doing so may be difficult both to say and to hear. If confrontations are examined in a caring and respectful manner, these interventions often promote change. It is essential that group members see that confrontation is a basic part of the group process, as it is of most every healthy relationship.

Leaders have a responsibility to teach members what confrontation *is* and what it *is not* and how to interact in constructive ways. Confrontation is not (1) tearing others down, (2) hitting others with negative feedback and then retreating, (3) being hostile with the aim of hurting others, (4) telling others what is basically wrong with them, or (5) assaulting others' integrity. Caring confrontation is designed to help members make an honest assessment of themselves or to speak more about their own reactions. Ideally, we see confrontation as a form of constructive feedback—an invitation for participants to look at some aspect of their interpersonal style or their lives to determine if they want to make changes.

There are variations in how people from different cultures confront others and in how they react to confrontations. In working with culturally diverse clients, it is important to remember that being "indirect" may be a cultural value for some group members. If confronted on their indirectness, or if they are expected to change, these group members may perceive such confrontations as signs of rudeness. They may even feel a sense of embarrassment, which could result in their deciding not to return to the group. Timing and sensitivity to members' cultural backgrounds are key factors in determining whether confrontations will be effective. A confrontation between people who share a similar culture may be addressed less defensively than one between members from different cultural or racial groups because they share some common understandings already. For example, comments between two African American males may be received less defensively than comments from a White male to a Black male.

In our work with groups, we provide members with these guidelines for appropriate and responsible confrontation:

- Members or leaders know why they are confronting.
- Confrontations are not dogmatic statements concerning who or what a person is.
- The person being confronted is told what effect he or she has on others rather than being labeled or judged or analyzed.
- Confrontations are more effective when they focus on specific, observable behaviors.
- One of the purposes of confrontation is to develop a closer and more genuine relationship with others.
- Sensitivity is an important element of effective confrontation; it is helpful for the person doing the confronting to imagine being the recipient of what is said.
- Those confronting might ask themselves if they are willing to do what they are asking others to do.
- Confrontation gives others the opportunity to reflect on the feedback they receive before they are expected to respond or to act on this feedback.
- Confrontation is a means to get a client to consider an alternative perspective.

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The quality of the confrontations that occur in a group is a measure of how effective the group is. The more cohesive a group, the more challenging the members and leaders can be.

To make the issue of confrontation more concrete, let's look at some examples. The first statement in each set illustrates an ineffective confrontation; this is followed by an effective confrontation statement. These examples show some of the ways group members might speak with one another. It is our role as leaders to model and to teach members to utilize the more *effective* ways of confronting. As you read each of these statements, imagine that you are the recipient of both the effective and ineffective confrontations. Take note of what it might be like to hear each of these statements. How would you be inclined to respond in each situation?

Ineffective: You're always giving everyone advice. I wish you would just focus on yourself for once.

Effective: It's difficult for me to listen to you when you give me advice. I would be more receptive if you told me more about your experiences.

Ineffective: You aren't getting anything from this group. You never talk, you just observe. We're just interesting cases for you.

Effective: I'd like to get to know you better. It's hard for me to feel close to you because you seem more interested in hearing from us than in sharing yourself.

Ineffective: You sound really homophobic.

Effective: You have made many generalizations about the LGBTQ community, and I feel hurt by what you have said. I would like for you to know me better, but I don't feel safe being more open and making myself vulnerable with you.

Ineffective: You're always so judgmental.

Effective: I feel uncomfortable with you because I'm afraid of what you think of me. Your opinion is important to me.

Ineffective: You are dishonest. You're always smiling, and that's not real.

Effective: I find it difficult to trust you. When you say you're angry, you're often smiling. That makes it hard for me to know what to believe.

Ineffective: I'm tired of your games.

Effective: I have trouble believing what you say. It bothers me that I feel this way with you, and I would like to talk to you about it.

In each of the ineffective statements, the people being confronted are being told how they are, and in some way they are being discounted. In the effective statements, the member doing the confronting is revealing his or her own perceptions and feelings about the other member: "When I am affected by you, what I say to you is about me too, not just about you." By not blaming others for their struggle, members can confront one another with respect and understanding.

Challenges to the Group Leader

Although leaders may be challenged throughout a group, they are more often confronted both personally and professionally during the transition stage. For example, several members may complain about not getting the "right" type of

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leadership, thereby challenging the leader's competence. It is a mistake for leaders to assume that every confrontation is an attack on their skills or integrity. Instead, they need to examine what is being said so they can differentiate between a *challenge* and an *attack*. How leaders respond to members' confrontations has a bearing on how trustingly the participants will approach confrontation in the future.

Oscar says to the leader, "I'm bored in here, and I wish you'd do something to make this a better group." A therapeutic response might include: "Tell me more about what you'd like from me or what you'd like from the group." "Say more about what's missing for you in this group." "What could you continue to do to make this a more meaningful group for you?" (By speaking up, Oscar has already taken the first step in changing the situation for himself.) It is not necessary that the leader quickly comply with Oscar's demand to conduct the group differently, but the leader should listen and promote a full expression of Oscar's dissatisfaction. The leader does not assume total responsibility for his boredom. However, she explores with Oscar their mutual responsibility to make this a meaningful and productive group, and she invites others to express their reactions to what is being said.

Though challenges may never be comfortable for the leader, it is important to recognize that these confrontations are often members' significant first steps toward testing the leader and thus becoming less dependent on the leader's approval. How a leader handles a confrontation to his or her leadership, at any stage, has a profound impact on the trust level in the group. Leaders can be good role models if they respond openly and avoid becoming defensive. If leaders are overly sensitive to criticism and have fragile egos, they are more likely to take such interchanges personally, which limits their effectiveness as well as the groups' ability to establish trust and openness with each other.

Many of the challenges described in this section may seem negative, pessimistic, difficult, and uncomfortable for both members and leaders. However, only when group members are ready to express their difficulties can there be a positive and productive outcome. Many of the topics in this chapter, if dealt with effectively, result in deepening interpersonal relationships, increasing cohesion, and increasing trust in the group.

The Leader's Reactions to Defensive Behaviors

LO8

Many forms of defensive behaviors emerge during the transition stage. It is important that you learn to recognize and deal with members' defenses, and that you become aware of your own reactions to the defensive behaviors exhibited by members. Some leaders have a tendency to focus on "problem members" or difficult situations rather than on their own dynamics and how they are affected personally when they encounter a difficult period in a group. Typically, leaders have a range of feelings: feeling threatened by what they perceive as a challenge to their leadership role; anger over the members' lack of cooperation and enthusiasm; feelings of inadequacy to the point of wondering if they are qualified to lead groups; resentment toward several of the members, whom they label as some type of problem; and anxiety over the slow pace of the group.

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Leaders who work with involuntary groups are likely to encounter uncooperative behaviors by members. A group proposal in Chapter 11 by Paul Jacobson, who designed a domestic violence group, provides a good example of a therapist working therapeutically with mandated groups. Paul Jacobson describes specific strategies he uses to minimize a lack of member cooperation and demonstrates how to maximize positive therapeutic outcomes. Even though individuals may be mandated to participate in group therapy, a therapist has many options for effectively dealing with a range of problematic behaviors.

One of the most powerful ways to intervene when you are experiencing intense feelings over what you perceive as defensiveness is to deal with your own feelings and possible defensive reactions to the situation. If you ignore your reactions, you are leaving yourself out of the interactions that occur in the group. Furthermore, by giving the members your reactions, you are modeling a direct style of dealing with conflict and problematic situations rather than bypassing them or putting up with them. Your own thoughts, feelings, and observations can be the most powerful resource you have in dealing with defensive behavior. When you share what you are feeling and thinking about what is going on in the group—without blaming or criticizing the members for deficiencies—you are letting the members experience an honest and constructive interaction with you. Doing this builds trust, which is often being tested during this stage. For many members, honesty from the leader is crucial to creating a working climate.

We hope you will keep these thoughts in mind as you read the next section, which deals with problem behaviors and difficult group members. Although it is understandable that you will want to learn how to handle "problem members" and the disruption they can cause, your emphasis should be on actual *behaviors* rather than on labeling members. It is helpful to consider problematic behaviors as manifestations of protecting the self that most participants display at one time or another during the course of a group.

LO9

Group Members Who Pose a Challenge for Leaders

Sometimes members become difficult because of problematic behaviors on the part of group leaders. But even in groups with the most effective group leader interventions, members have the potential to display problematic behaviors that are a source of difficulty to themselves, other members, and the leader. In establishing norms that minimize problematic behaviors, leaders do well to provide the members with a rationale for not engaging in particular nonproductive behaviors. For example, when members ask why they are discouraged from asking questions, from giving advice, or from telling detailed stories, members deserve a full response. It is the leader's task to educate members to involve themselves in productive group behaviors that will maximize the benefits of their group experience. Leaders can assist members in communicating more effectively. Leaders need to be mindful of how their interventions can either decrease or escalate members' problematic behaviors.

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The basic purpose of a therapeutic group is to provide people with opportunities to see themselves in a new light and get a more accurate picture of how others perceive them. To facilitate insight and change, the leader should not rush in too quickly in an attempt to eradicate difficult behaviors. Initially, the leader should observe the group to ascertain whether members see themselves as causing problems for themselves or others and to discover what members might be attempting to communicate through their behavior. Both other members and the leader must be patient and nonjudgmental if defensive behaviors are to give way to more constructive expressions. A productive group experience can teach members that they do not have to persist in behavioral patterns that are no longer working for them. With the security afforded in a group, members can begin to take risks and discover more effective ways of being.

We have found some of these interventions helpful when interacting with group members who posed a difficulty for us:

- Express your difficulty with a member without denigrating the character of the person.
- Avoid responding to sarcasm with sarcasm.
- Educate the members about how the group works.
- Encourage members to explore their defensiveness rather than too quickly expecting them to give up their ways of protecting themselves.
- Avoid labeling a member and instead describe the behavior of the member.
- Do your best to state observations and hunches in a tentative way as opposed to being dogmatic.
- Demonstrate sensitivity to a member's culture and avoid stereotyping the individual.
- Monitor your own countertransference reactions.
- Challenge and encourage members in a caring and respectful way to do things that may be painful and difficult.
- Find ways to explore the conflict rather than retreating from it.
- Avoid personalizing members' reactions, and do not respond in overly defensive ways.
- Strive to facilitate an exploration of a problem rather than offering simple or quick solutions.
- Pay attention and be honest about instances when you are meeting your own needs at the expense of your clients.
- Invite group members to state how they are personally affected by problematic behaviors of other members while blocking judgments, evaluations, and criticisms.
- If members evoke reactions in you, share this in a way that is therapeutic or process it with your coleader or your supervisor.

Leaders need to be mindful of how their interventions can either decrease or escalate members' problematic behaviors.

Be aware of your power as the group leader, and recognize the impact of the power differential between members and leaders. Take a look at your own behavior and examine whether your personal reactions might be creating some of the client's defensive behaviors. Answer these questions:

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- What am I thinking and feeling as I work with this client?
- What am I doing to create or exacerbate the problems?
- Does the client remind me of anyone in my personal life?
- What is it about this individual that presents difficulty for me?

When working with behaviors that are counterproductive to group functioning, it is useful to understand the meaning these behaviors have for the individual member. People in a group are likely doing the best they know how, even if they become aware that what they are doing is not working well for them. We must remind ourselves that the very reason people seek a group is to assist them in finding more effective ways of expressing themselves and dealing with others. When group leaders understand the dynamics of various problematic behaviors, they can find ways to therapeutically manage and explore these behaviors in a group. If you find yourself frequently questioning your ability to lead a group, seek supervision or the support of a colleague. Use these opportunities to grow both personally and professionally, and recognize that you are learning and that it is normal to have some doubts.

Silence and Lack of Participation

Silence and lack of participation are two forms of behavior that most group leaders encounter. Even though the verbally silent member may not seem to interfere with a group's functioning, this behavior may constitute a problem for both the member and the group. If quiet members go unnoticed, their pattern of silence could hide a problem that may need to be addressed in the group. Typically members are affected by people who are silent in a group.

Some silent group members may argue that their lack of verbal participation is not due to lack of their involvement. They may maintain that they are learning by listening and by identifying with others' problems. These members may say, "I feel like what others are saying is more important then what I have to say." Or "I don't want to interrupt people when they are talking, so I wait and then what I have to say doesn't seem relevant anymore." Group leaders need to explore the meaning of silence with the members. When members say that they are uncomfortable verbally participating, we have no way of knowing how they are affected by what is going on during the sessions. They may be triggered by other members' explorations, and if they do not talk about this, then being in the group can be counterproductive for them and the group.

Group leaders need to avoid consistently calling on a silent person, for in this way the member is relieved of the responsibility of initiating interactions. This can lead to resentment on the part of both the member who is silent and the rest of the group, as well as frustration on the part of the leader. However, leaders may need to increase their efforts to include members of some cultural groups so that they become comfortable enough to participate in the group. There are many potential reasons for nonparticipating behavior:

- Showing respect and waiting to be called on by the leader.
- Feeling that one does not have anything worthwhile to say.
- Feeling that one should not talk about oneself or that one should be seen and not heard.

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- Uncertainty about how the group process works, such as the fear of not knowing what is appropriate and when to make comments.
- A fear of certain members in the group or of the authority of the group leader.
- A protection against oppression from the leader or other members.
- Fear of being rejected.
- Lack of trust in the group.
- Unexpressed feelings of anger with group members or leaders.
- Fears about confidentiality.
- Feeling that one doesn't measure up when compared with other group members.

It is important that members not feel chastised for their silence but instead be invited to participate. Approach such members by expressing concerns rather than judgments about their silence. Leaders can work to help quiet members share themselves in a number of creative ways. It may be helpful to explore whether the member has other avenues of self-expression, such as art, poetry, or music. Thinking outside the box can open creative ways to participate not only for quiet members but for all members.

Another way of encouraging quiet members to participate is to watch for their nonverbal reactions to what others are saying. You can comment on what you are observing and use this as a way to bring them in. For example, if Nora is talking about her experience with her abusive mother and you notice a "quiet" member tearing up or listening intently, you might say, "You seemed to be touched emotionally by what Nora was saying. Would you be willing to tell Nora what she is bringing up in you?"

At times leaders and members may focus so much on active verbal participation that they miss the richness of the nonverbal communication clients from various cultural backgrounds may exhibit. All members will not participate equally, and some members may need more time to establish trust. Understanding members' cultural norms can shed light on their lack of verbal participation. When leading groups with a diverse population, counselors must recognize and appreciate the various ways in which people make themselves known, both verbally and nonverbally.

It is often useful to invite members to explore what their silence means. For example, are they this way outside of the group as well? How does it feel for them to be in this group? Have they any desire to be more verbally active participants? The rest of the group can participate in this discussion, for group members generally do have reactions to silent members. They may feel cheated that they know so little of that person, or they may fear that the person is observing them as they risk and reveal themselves. If there are several participants who rarely talk in a group, the verbally active members may become less revealing because of trust issues.

The checkout process at the end of a group session is often used to prompt minimal participation from quiet members. This is a less threatening way for members who tend to be quiet to share how they are experiencing the group. It is also important to teach nonparticipating members that others in the group are more likely to project onto them if they say very little during the sessions. The leader may ask members to make a contract to participate at every session, sharing with

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the group at some point how they responded to the session that day. They can also be asked toward the end of a meeting what it was like for them to be in the group. A leader might ask them if they are getting from the group what they had wanted. If they indicate that there were moments when they wanted to participate, but that time ran out before they got a chance, they can be invited to make a contract to be first on the agenda at the next group meeting.

Monopolistic Behavior

At the other end of the participation continuum is the person who exhibits a high degree of self-centeredness by monopolizing the activities of the group. The member who monopolizes often claims to identify with others but takes others' statements as openings for detailed stories about his or her own life. This person prevents others from getting their share of group time. People sometimes operate under the assumption that a good group member is one who talks a lot. Leaders need to help these members explore the possible dynamics of their behavior. They may be talking excessively out of anxiety, they may be accustomed to being ignored, they may be attempting to keep control of the group, or they may be members of privileged status who are accustomed to having others listen to them and take advantage of any opportunity to speak. These monopolizing members may talk a lot, but the end result is similar to that of silent members: they reveal very little about themselves.

During the beginning stage of a group, members as well as some leaders may be relieved that someone else is going first, and no one will intervene to stop the person from taking center stage. As time goes on, however, both leaders and members will become increasingly frustrated. As meetings continue, the group generally becomes less tolerant of the person who monopolizes, and unless these feelings of annoyance are dealt with early, they may be released in an explosive way.

For both ethical and practical reasons, it is essential that the monopolizing person be respectfully challenged to look at the effects of such behavior on the group. Ethical practice dictates that group leaders acquire intervention skills necessary to block rambling. It is desirable that the leader intervene before the members react out of frustration and become hostile. Here are some possible leader interventions:

- "Tanya, you seem to participate a lot, and I notice that you identify with most of the problems that are raised. I am not sure I know what you are trying to tell us. In one sentence, what do you most want us to hear?"
- "Tanya, you say a lot. I wonder if you're willing to go around the room to different members and finish the following sentence: 'What I most want you to hear about me is . . .'." Other possible incomplete sentences that could lead to fruitful exploration include "If I didn't talk . . ." "If I let others talk . . ." "I have a lot to say because . . ." "When people don't listen to me I feel . . ." "I want you to listen to me because . . ."

Tanya can be asked to make the rounds by addressing each person in the group through the process of completing any one of these sentences. It is important for her not to elaborate or explain but to say the first thing that comes to her mind.

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It is best to instruct members not to respond during the go-around. Through such exercises we usually discover crucial information that helps everyone get a better sense of the function served by the monopolizing behavior.

Assume that another member, Vance, confronts Tanya in a hostile manner before the leader has said anything about her behavior. Vance asks Tanya: "Why don't you stop talking for a change? Do you think you're the only one who has something to say?" An appropriate leader intervention could be, "Vance, I hear your frustration with Tanya. Could you say a bit more to Tanya about how she is affecting you without judging her? It might also help to share with her what you were feeling and thinking before you spoke up."

We can dismiss Tanya's behavior as simply a nuisance, or we can see it as a defense and encourage her to explore her defenses, as we would any other defense mechanism. Consider that she initially appeared to be a motivated member, yet she seemed to try too hard to fit into the group. She revealed personal aspects of herself, she readily made suggestions to others, she could identify with most who spoke, and she told detailed stories of her past. Although Tanya might not express this, her behavior could be conveying the message "Please notice me and like me." In her own mind she may have felt that she was doing what was expected of her and viewed herself as an eager participant. One of the issues that she had initially presented to look at was her difficulty in getting close to people. She acknowledged that she had few friends and that people were typically annoyed with her, which she found perplexing. By confronting Tanya in an honest and sensitive manner, the leader can help her learn what she is doing that prevents her from getting close to people. She may discover that during her childhood she was often ignored and no one listened to her. She may have decided that if she didn't talk a lot, she would be ignored, or if she tried a little harder, people would respond to her. The fact is that her familiar behavior is not getting her what she wants, either inside or outside the group. The group experience offers her the possibility of finding ways that can satisfy her wants.

A leader can approach difficult members like Tanya with a sense of interest. The leader's *internal* dialogue might go something like this: "How is it that Tanya is working so hard at getting me to pay attention to her, yet I have no sense of her? How is it that she can get a whole group of people to be angry with her? How is she replicating, in this group, behavior that is problematic on the outside?" You cannot be effective with Tanya if all you feel toward her is annoyance. Instead, explore the context of how her behavior might make sense in her life. Alternatively, ask yourself, "Is there something I am doing that is making it difficult for her to be different in this group?"

Many times our most challenging members have become the people we most treasure.

At times student leaders comment that they would not want a particular member (such as Tanya) in their group because the person is problematic. We do our best to help them shift this attitude toward a more accepting stance because some members will go out of their way to make themselves unlovable. Oftentimes the members who do the most damage have also been the most damaged. As group leaders, we need to find a way to help members who affect us negatively to profit from the group despite our initial reaction to them. If we are able to see the

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difficult behavior as symptomatic of pain rather than as a sign of the person's character, we are more likely to develop patience and intervene effectively with this member. Many times our most challenging members have become the people we most treasure.

Storytelling

Self-disclosure is frequently misunderstood by some group members to imply a lengthy recitation of their lives, both past and present. If they are confronted about the excessive details of their history, they may express resentment, maintaining that they are risking disclosing themselves. In teaching group process, leaders need to differentiate between storytelling, which is merely talking about oneself or about others in great detail, and disclosure, which is talking about what a person is thinking and feeling now. Questions the leader should consider include the following: "Does the story help me to understand the member better, or does it distract me from hearing and understanding her problem?" "Does the story give me information to better assist the member in reaching his goal?"

During the beginning stages of a group, some members may express themselves through telling stories. People who are new to groups frequently need to hear facts about others or to share some of their own past to become comfortable in the group. However, if storytelling behavior becomes the norm (either for the whole group or for one member), the leader should recognize this problem and deal with it. For example, if Vincent presents a detailed story about how he is treated by his boss, we would be inclined to focus on how he is feeling rather than on the details of his story. We might intervene in this way: "How does this situation affect you? What is it like for you to have such a strained relationship with her? You seem to be talking more about your boss right now than about yourself. Tell us about *you*, Vincent." The group leader's task is to help members move beyond simply telling irrelevant stories and teach them to express themselves in personal and concrete ways. This requires active intervention on the leader's part. The group leader might say, "If I allowed you only one sentence to express what you have just said, what would it be?" Vincent's detailed story could be simply stated as "I resent my boss for the way she treats me!"

Leaders need to be able to distinguish between storytelling that is healing and meaningful to members and counterproductive storytelling. We can assist members in sharing the essence of their concern without getting lost in their story. For example, Angelica typically told every detail of her earlier experiences, but even though the group knew a lot about the events in her past, they knew very little about what she thought about or how she felt about what she had experienced. She believed she was being open in sharing her private life with the group, yet her group wanted to know more about how she was affected by her life situations. The group leader let her know that he was indeed interested in knowing her but that the information she was offering was not helping him do so.

Used as a defense, storytelling can be any form of talking about out-of-group life that is done in a detached manner. Although the member telling the story is giving many details, he or she is unknown. Feedback from the group given directly, without judgment, can assist the person to speak in personal terms and keep the

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focus on feelings, thoughts, and reactions. However, all storytelling should not be thought of as negative or as a sign of avoidance. Leaders can assist members in telling their stories in a way that is likely to keep the interest of others. Ultimately, members need to reveal their stories in ways that enable them to reach their personal goals. One way to enliven members' presentations of self is to ask them to write their stories as a homework assignment and then only share in the group what it was like to have done this assignment.

Questioning

Another counterproductive form of behavior in the group is questioning that resembles interrogation. Some members develop a style of relating that involves questioning others, and they intervene at inappropriate times in unhelpful ways. Leaders can teach people who habitually ask questions to see that this behavior generally is not helpful for them or for others. Asking questions of others may be a way of hiding, of remaining safe and unknown in a group. It also directs them toward others, not themselves. It is helpful to teach members that questions tend to direct people toward thinking and away from feelings they may be experiencing at the moment.

Rather than repeatedly saying "Don't ask questions; make statements," leaders can educate members about the function of questions and how asking questions often interferes with an individual's process. Questions can be very intrusive and put others on the spot while the questioner doesn't reveal anything about him- or herself. We usually invite the person asking the question to state what prompted him or her to ask the question. For example, if Miriam asked another member why he was so quiet, the leader could encourage her to say what had been going on in her mind before she asked the question. Miriam may tell the leader, "I noticed that Joel hardly says anything, and I'm interested in him and would like to get to know him." With such a statement Miriam discloses her investment in her question without putting Joel on the spot. Questions often arouse defensiveness, whereas personal statements are less likely to do so.

Because questions do not tell the entire story, we typically ask members who raise them to fill in the details. We might say: "What prompted you to ask . . . ?" "How come you want to know . . . ?" "What are you aware of right now that makes you want to ask that question?" Or "Tell [the person] what led up to your question." Here are some examples of questions and the possible hidden messages they contain:

- "How old are you?" ("I'm much older than you, and I wonder if I'll be able to identify with you.")
- "Why did you make Shirley cry?" ("I don't trust what you did, and I would never open myself up to you the way she did.")
- "Why do you push people so hard?" ("I'm scared, and I don't know how far I want to go.")
- "Why are you laughing?" ("I don't think you take seriously what goes on in this group.")
- "What do you think of me?" ("I like and respect you, and your view of me matters a lot.")

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- "Why don't you leave your husband?" ("I care about you and the way you struggle, and I wonder what influences your decision to stay.")
- "Why do you always criticize your parents?" ("I'm a parent, and I wonder if my kids criticize me.")

Teaching members how to share themselves through statements rather than questioning is most effective when done in a timely, appropriate, and sensitive manner as these behaviors or interactions occur in the session.

Giving Advice

A problem behavior related to questioning is giving advice. It is one thing to offer a perception or an opinion to other members and quite another to tell people what they should feel or what they should or should not do. We often ask members to share the way in which they struggle with a particular problem rather than give others their suggested solutions to a problem. Giving advice is not always done directly, such as "I think what you ought to do is . . . ." The advice giving may be subtle: "You shouldn't feel guilty that your parents divorced because that was their decision and not something you made them do." Although this is true, the point is that the young woman does feel guilty and believes her parents might still be married if it had not been for her. It does not serve the best interest of the woman to advise her not to feel guilty. She has to resolve this feeling herself. The man who had a need to tell her that she shouldn't feel guilty could profit from examining his own motives for wanting to remove the guilt. What does it say about him? At this point the focus might be shifted to the person giving advice, and the meaning of his giving such advice can be explored.

Sometimes advice giving is less subtle. Nisha has been considering not only leaving her husband but also leaving her two teenage daughters with him. She thinks she wants to live alone, but she feels somewhat guilty. Robin intervenes: "Nisha, you owe it to yourself to do what you want to do. You have been the main caregiver for 9 years. Why not let him have major time with them?" This type of behavior raises a lot of questions about Robin. What are her values and possible unresolved problems? Why does she feel a need to so direct Nisha? Could Robin talk about herself instead of deciding what is best for Nisha? The group might now focus on Robin's need to provide others with solutions. Robin might learn about what she is getting from giving advice, and she may need to learn that what works for her might not work for others.

Advice giving has the tendency to interrupt the expression of thoughts and feelings and to increase dependency. If Nisha is given enough time to explore her conflict more fully, she will be better able to make her own decision. In essence, an abundance of advice tells her that she is not capable of finding her own way, and it conditions her to become more dependent on others for direction. Even if the advice given is helpful and sound, in the long run it does not teach Nisha the process of finding her own solutions to new problems as they occur. It is more helpful for members to share their own struggles than to provide ready-made solutions.

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Both members and leaders need to acquire the skill of assisting others in arriving at their own insights about actions they need to take to bring about the changes they desire. Certainly leaders can provide information and ideas to members for coping with difficulties. However, it is more powerful and creates less dependency if members are first asked about their own thoughts about resolving challenging situations. By paying attention to the process rather than being wedded to a specific outcome, leaders can assist members in examining the consequences of their decisions and what outcomes they can best live with. For example, if a group member is contemplating whether to disclose that he is gay in his work environment, it is not our job to push him in a certain direction, nor is dispensing advice generally helpful. It is the client who must live with the decision he makes, not the leader. To help members learn how to solve problems, the leader may ask: "What have you done that has worked or not worked well for you?" "What advice might you give to yourself?" This may be especially relevant in working with members from cultures in which advice giving is seen as a positive way to connect with others.

As a group leader, you must be clear about the goals and purposes of the groups you design and facilitate. Furthermore, it is essential that you inform potential members about the purpose of the group during the screening and orientation meetings. Some psychoeducational groups are designed specifically to provide information and guidance and to teach specific skills. At times, people will join a group with the particular intention of getting advice on solving their problems. These group members may view you as an expert whose job it is to provide them with suggestions and specialized knowledge. Discuss the expectations of members who are seeking advice, and inform them if this is indeed something you will be offering.

Dependency

Group members who are excessively dependent typically look either to the group leader or to the other members to direct them and take care of them. Leaders sometimes foster member dependency. Some leaders have a great desire to be wanted and needed, and they feel a sense of importance when participants rely on them. This is an example of the leader's unmet psychological needs interfering with the therapeutic outcome of a group. Leaders may collude with members to form a dependent alliance for many reasons:

- The leader may need the economic rewards from the members' attendance.
- The group may be filling the leader's unmet needs for a social life.
- Some leaders have a need to be parental in the sense of directing others' lives.
- Leaders may rely on their groups as the primary source of feeling appreciated and recognized.
- Leaders may attempt to work through their own unresolved conflicts by using the group.

These examples show how the personality of the leader cannot be separated from what sometimes appears as problem behavior within the group. The behaviors of the leader and the members have a reciprocal effect on each other.

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Dependent behavior is not always problematic. Such behavior needs to be viewed through a cultural lens to determine its function. What may be viewed in one culture as a manifestation of overly dependent behavior might well be viewed by another culture as an appropriate behavioral norm. As is true of seeking and giving advice, the member's cultural background must be considered along with their stated behavioral change goals.

Offering Pseudosupport

Like questioning and giving advice, providing inappropriate support needs to be examined for the meaning it holds for the person who offers it. People who have little tolerance for feeling their own pain may find it difficult to sit with the pain of others. These supportive individuals may attempt to distract a member who is expressing pain, not realizing the healing power of being able to share a painful experience. For example, Ernesto was finally able to feel his sadness over the distance between his sons and himself, and he cried as he talked about how much he wanted to be a better father. Before Ernesto could express what he was feeling, Randy put his hands on Ernesto's shoulders and tried to reassure him that he wasn't such a bad father because at least he lived with his kids. Randy might have wanted to make Ernesto feel better so that he himself would feel more comfortable. Members who want to bypass experiencing painful emotions often do so because of their own discomfort with these emotions. However, in the process of doing so, Ernesto was cut off from finally being able to express some of the sadness locked up inside of him.

There is a real difference between offering pseudosupport and behavior that is a genuine expression of care, concern, and empathy. When there is real caring, the interests of the members who are experiencing the pain are given paramount importance. Sometimes it is best to allow them to experience the depths of their pain; ultimately, they may be better off for having done so. The release of pain is often the necessary first step toward healing. This is a lesson that may need to be explicitly stated by the leader.

The release of pain is often the necessary first step toward healing.

Touching can be a genuine expression of caring that comforts a member who is experiencing pain, but sometimes it can get in the member's way. It is useful to talk with members about the pros and cons of touch and of the ways in which it can support or interrupt a member's process. The motivation behind the touch is crucial. Does the person offering touch want to communicate "I can't tolerate seeing you in pain, and I want you to stop"? Or is the person saying "I know how hard this is for you, and I want you to know that I support you"? It is surprising to us how often people who are in pain accurately pick up the message of the touch.

Hostile Behavior

Hostility is difficult to deal with in a group because it is often indirect. Hostility can take the form of caustic remarks, jokes, sarcasm, and other passive-aggressive tactics. Members can express their resentment by missing group sessions, coming

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late, acting obviously detached, leaving the group, being overly polite, or rolling their eyes to express boredom or annoyance. Extremely hostile people are not good candidates for a group because they can have a devastating effect on the group climate. People are not going to make themselves vulnerable if there is a good chance that they will be ridiculed or in some other way devalued. If hostile behavior is not confronted in a group, it can hold the group members and the group process hostage. We have witnessed some situations in which the hostile member was so powerful that the other members did not want to confront the individual, thus giving him or her even more control over the group.

One way to deal with the person who behaves in a hostile way is to request that he or she listen without responding while the group members tell how they are being affected by that individual. The techniques for caring confrontation described earlier should be modeled in this discussion. Members can describe how they feel in the group with the hostile person and what they would like the person to do differently. Then it should be ascertained what the hostile individual wants from the group. Hostile behavior may be a manifestation of fear of getting intimate or of a limited capacity for vulnerability. If the fears underneath the hostility can be brought to the surface and dealt with, the hostility may decrease.

For example, Karl, who has a good relationship in the group with Sana, suddenly calls her a "control freak." Before she has a chance to express her surprise, hurt, and anger, he tells her that he sees his wife in her and that it is not really her he is upset with. Karl has attempted to take back what he said, yet Sana is still stuck with her hurt feelings. On an intellectual level Sana may understand that Karl is transferring his reactions to her, but on an emotional level she is hurt and has become distrustful of him. Sana needs some time to recover emotionally. Eventually, Karl acknowledges that he indeed had some negative feelings toward her personally, not just as his symbolic wife. But he wanted to quickly retreat when he saw that she had responded strongly.

Individuals who grew up in families in which they received attention primarily for negative behaviors often repeat these dynamics within the group by activating a negative response from both leaders and members. One member we worked with lashed out with criticism, hostility, and sarcasm whenever she felt a tinge of vulnerability. Kara's sarcasm was a mask she wore that externally communicated to others, "I don't care about you." Her more honest message might have been, "I care too much, and I'm afraid you'll hurt me." This type of behavior can be exhausting to deal with, and it is tempting for leaders to respond to this hostility with frustration and anger. By working with members to find the functions served by their hostility within the group as well as within their family history, "hostile" members can become less defensive. As with most of our defenses, hostility provides a barrier that protects us. If we first examine the way in which these behaviors serve us, it is easier to choose alternate and healthier methods of self-protection.

Acting Superior

Some group members take on an attitude of superiority. They may be moralistic and find ways to judge or criticize others for their behavior. They are unable to

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identify any pressing problems in their lives. Their attitude and behavior tend to have the same effect on a group as hostility. Participants freeze up, for they are more hesitant to expose their weaknesses to someone who projects an image of being perfect. Take the example of Arron, who says, "My problems are nothing compared to yours. I feel sorry that so many of you had such terrible childhoods, and I feel fortunate that my parents really loved me." Arron is likely to respond to someone who is sharing a problem with "I used to have your problem, but I don't anymore." He will antagonize others with comments such as "I can identify with you, because at one time I was where you are."

You can challenge Arron's comments by asking him what he wants from the group. Here is one possible intervention: "You're comparing your problems with those of others in here. What is it that you'd like to get from this group? How is it for you to be here? How are you being affected personally by what you're hearing? How does it feel that people are annoyed with you?" This intervention lessens the chances of pressuring Arron to come up with problems that he is likely to deny having. Instead, it gives him some room to talk about how he is being affected in the group. Taking an argumentative stance generally leads to a fruitless and frustrating debate. It is more constructive to explore the reasons Arron continues to come to the group.

Another option is to ask group members to respond to Arron by letting him know how his behavior is affecting them. It is important, however, that members speak about themselves and not judge Arron. Ask Arron if he is open to hearing feedback about how his behavior is affecting others, and be careful to moderate the amount of feedback given. If it appears that Arron is getting more feedback than he can assimilate at one time, the leader may intervene by saying, "Perhaps Arron has enough to think about right now. Let's focus more on what is going on with each of us." It is also crucial to block a tendency to use Arron as a scapegoat and to insist that he needs to have a problem.

Socializing

In certain groups, member socialization within the group, and even outside the group, is encouraged. When members meet outside of group sessions, group cohesion can be increased. They can extend what they are learning in their group to the informal gatherings. Such meetings can also be useful in challenging members to follow through with their plans and commitments. For some populations, such as an inpatient group for older adults, this may be their only network of support. Group leaders should have an open discussion with members about the ways in which these out-of-group relationships can be an asset and the types of problems that can arise when social relationships are formed and not managed well within a group dynamic.

Some types of out-of-group relationships can be problematic and impede group cohesion. This is especially true when participants form subgroups and talk about group matters but are unwilling to share what they talked about in the group sessions. Other signs that indicate counterproductive socializing include forming cliques and excluding certain members from such gatherings, forming romantic involvements without a willingness to share them in the group, refusing

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to challenge one another in the group for fear of jeopardizing friendships, and relying on the group exclusively as the source of social life.

When meetings outside of the sessions hamper group progress, it is crucial that this situation be openly examined by the group. You can ask the members if they are genuinely committed to developing the kind of group that will function effectively. You can help them see that forming cliques and making pacts to keep information out of the regular sessions is counterproductive and impedes group development.

Intellectualizing

Most of us rely on thinking, and nothing is amiss in using our intellectual faculties. When intellectualizing is used as a defense against experiencing feelings, however, it may become problematic in a person's life and in his or her functioning in a group. When group members discuss emotionally laden topics in a very detached way as though out of intellectual interest, they can be said to be intellectualizing. For maximum effect, it is best that cognitive and affective work be integrated.

People who intellectualize need to be made aware of what they are doing. A question you might raise with members who rely heavily on their intellect is this: "Does what you are doing most of the time get you what you want? Is this something you want to change?" Some experiential techniques (borrowed from Gestalt therapy and psychodrama) can be useful in helping these group members more directly experience the emotions associated with the events they talk about. Clients can be directed to reexperience events in the here and now through role playing.

Group leaders do well to avoid making quick judgments about members who do not readily display intense emotions and labeling them as "removed from their feelings" or "detached" or pathologizing in their interpersonal style. For many people, operating from a cognitive perspective may be more culturally appropriate than displaying feelings publicly. It is more beneficial to help members identify when this style of communication works for them, and the times when it works against them. It is easier to help members make adjustments to their defenses than to have them eradicate these coping mechanisms entirely.

It is important to avoid communicating that intellectualization is undesirable; the strengths of this type of communication should be acknowledged. Although it may not serve the person well relationally, this style of communication may be related to one's gender or vocation. Male clients are more apt to utilize intellectualization in their communication style as a result of gender socialization. For example, Miguel learned to use his intellect to get him through difficulties in his life. He admits that he would like to add an emotional dimension in addition to relying on his intellect. It is important to help Miguel see the use of intellectualization on a continuum, and to help him explore the ways in which it works for him and how it might not. If you approach Miguel with the goal of fine tuning his communication style as opposed to giving up his style, he is much more likely to be open to working on his learned patterns and consider augmenting his behaviors.

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Members Becoming Assistant Leaders

Another way that group members may distance themselves is by aligning themselves with the leaders. These members protect themselves from vulnerability by developing an interpersonal style of taking on the role of assistant leaders, asking questions, probing for information, attempting to give advice, and paying attention to the dynamics of individuals and the group. Instead of paying attention to how they may be affected in the group, they shift the focus to others by making interventions and assuming a counselor's role. Members who take refuge in adopting such a role are deprived of the opportunity to work on the problems that brought them to the group in the first place. They can be challenged to evaluate whether what they are doing will get them what they ultimately want. It is necessary to deal with this problematic behavior because it is likely to be resented by other members, and it often impedes the progress of a group.

Recognizing this behavior as a possible defense, the leader can sensitively block it by pointing out to such members that they are depriving themselves of the maximum benefit from the group by paying more attention to others than to themselves. They joined the group to explore their own concerns, and they can lose sight of this goal if they leave themselves out of the process by constantly assuming leadership functions. These members should not be chastised or dismissed for their way of interacting; rather, they can be asked to look at the possible motivations for their behavior. They need to determine if they are pursuing their goals for this group experience.

LO9

Dealing With Defensive Behavior Therapeutically

Many interventions can facilitate working *with* challenging group members rather than fighting them. The statements that follow may help members get beyond their reluctance to fully participate. First we give examples of comments that illustrate a particular hesitation or difficulty. These are followed by several responses leaders may employ that often help clients move forward. Of course, not all these responses are made simultaneously to each member comment.

Randy: I don't know.

Leader: Pretend you know. And if you did know, what might you say?

What do you know?

What are you aware of as you look at me or others in the room?

Say the first thing that comes to your mind.

Henry [*during a role play*]: I don't know what to say to my father.

Leader: That's a good place to start. Tell him that.

If this is the last chance you have to speak to him, what do you want to tell him?

If you were your father, what would you want to say? If you were your father, what do you fear you would say?

Tell your father what stops you from talking to him.

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Sylvana: I try so hard to say things the right way.

Leader: Say the first thing that comes to your mind right now.

Rehearse out loud.

What do you fear will happen if you say things the wrong way?

Kate: I don't want to be here.

Leader: Where would you rather be?

What makes it difficult for you to be here?

Who or what made you come here?

What made you come if you didn't want to be here today?

Valerie [*after an intense piece of work*]: I don't want the spotlight on me any longer.

Leader: What or whom do you want to get away from?

Go to a few people and finish the sentence: "I want to get away from you because . . ."

Say more about your feeling.

Sophia: I'm afraid to talk more about this.

Leader: Can you talk about what's stopping you?

What do you fear would happen if you said more?

What do you imagine will happen if you don't talk about it?

What would it take for you to feel safer in here?

I hope you'll say more about your fears of talking.

Several Members: It's far easier to talk in the coffee shop to other group members than it is to express ourselves here.

Leader: Form an inner circle. Imagine you're out having coffee. What are you saying to each other?

Say at least two things to several members about your difficulty in being here. (Some possibilities for incomplete sentences to be completed by a client are: "I find it hard to talk in here because . . . ," "I'm afraid to talk because . . . ," and "When I stop myself from talking, I'm most aware of. . . .")

Joel: I'm very uncomfortable with the anger in the group.

Leader: Tell those whom you see as angry how you're affected by them.

What happens [happened] when people express [expressed] their anger in your life? (Some possibilities for incomplete sentences to be completed by the client are: "I'm afraid to get angry like this because . . . ," "When you're angry with me, I . . . ," "I'm afraid of my anger because . . . ," and "When I witness anger, I want to. . . .")

Chelsea [*who typically engages in storytelling*]: But you don't understand. I need to tell you all the details so that you'll understand me.

Leader: Bear with me. I have a hard time following you when you give so many details. In one sentence, what do you most want me to hear?

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What is it like not to feel understood in this group?

What is it like to discover that people don't want to hear your stories?

How does this story relate to the way you are struggling now in your life?

What makes it important that I listen to your story?

Erica: I feel that my problems are insignificant.

Leader: Whose problems in here are more important?

If you didn't compare your problems with those of others, what could you tell us about yourself?

How are you affected by hearing all these problems?

Tell us about one of your insignificant problems.

Skylar [*who has been feeling close to others in the group*]: I'm afraid of this closeness, because I'm sure it won't last.

Leader: What did you do to get close to people?

Tell a few people what scares you about remaining close to them.

Tell us how you can get close in here but not in your life.

What would it be like for you if you had people close to you? What is one thing that might keep you from maintaining the closeness you felt?

If nothing changed for you, how might this be? Tell us the advantages of isolating yourself.

Kyle [*who is typically silent*]: I don't think I need to be talking all the time. I learn a lot by observing.

Leader: Tell us some things you have been observing.

Are you satisfied with being silent, or would you like to change?

What are some of the things that make it difficult to speak out more?

Would you be willing to select two people you've been observing and tell them how they have affected you?

I'm interested in knowing what you have to say, and I'd like to hear from you.

When you observe me and quietly make assumptions about me, I feel uncomfortable. I'd like to be included in the conclusions you're drawing about me. I hope you are open to that.

When you don't talk about yourself, people are likely to project onto you, and there's a good chance you'll be misunderstood.

Perry [*who tends to give people advice*]: I think you should stop criticizing yourself because you're a wonderful person.

Leader: For several weeks now you've observed people in this room. Give each person an important piece of advice.

When you give advice, does it remind you of anyone you know?

How is it for you when your advice is rejected?

What triggers the advice you give to others?

Would you be willing to share what you are feeling when you give advice?

Are you able to receive advice from others? Is it always helpful?

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Most of these suggestions for responses by the leader provide encouragement for members to say more rather than stopping at the point of initial resistance. The questions are open ended and are presented in an invitational manner. The interventions all grow out of clues provided by members, and they are designed to offer directions clients might pursue in becoming unstuck.

LO10

Dealing With Avoidance by the Whole Group

We have focused on how to deal therapeutically with the defensive behaviors of individuals, but sometimes an entire group exhibits behavior that makes it almost impossible to achieve a productive level of work. In this section we (Marianne and Jerry) describe one of our experiences when this was the case. This illustrates what might happen if an entire group makes the choice of not working and demonstrates an unwillingness to deal with several hidden agendas. We also describe some ways these hidden agendas affect the members as individuals as well as the group as a whole.

At one of our training workshops for group counselors, it was not possible to individually screen candidates. In lieu of screening, we provided all who were interested with a detailed letter describing the workshop and outlining our expectations of participants. We repeated this information at the first session, and participants had an opportunity to raise questions. It was especially crucial to us that they understood that they were to become personally involved and would function both as members and as coleaders during different sessions. The group was divided into two groups of eight. As supervisors, we changed groups after each 2-hour session. This change presented problems for some of the trainees, who said they were inhibited because the same supervisor was not continually in their group.

Group 1 was formed by people who got up and actively chose to be with one another. By contrast, Group 2 was largely formed by one member who remained seated and said: "I'm staying here. Anyone who wants to join my group can come over here." As the week progressed, some interesting differences arose between the two groups. Group 2 was characterized by an unwillingness to meaningfully interact with one another. Many of them complained that they had not understood that they were to become personally invested in the group process. They said they had expected to learn about groups by observing us do the work rather than by getting actively involved. Although a few of the members disclosed readily, others refused to share and did very little interacting, which eventually led to an increased sense of withholding on the part of all members.

The participants in Group 2 were apparently feeling many things that they had not disclosed. Some of them said that they were enjoying the group time, yet most of them were reticent to participate and appeared disinterested. During the breaks, members talked about difficulties they were experiencing in the sessions, but they did not bring this information back to their group. Two members ended a session with an unresolved conflict and decided to clear the air during the break, but they did not inform the group of the outcome. Only after some exploration by the supervisor did the members eventually acknowledge that they

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were preoccupied and concerned about the two people who had had the conflict. The supervisor attempted to teach again how subgrouping can be deleterious to a group's level of trust.

Several women in Group 2 confronted one of the male members in a harsh manner. When a supervisor asked how he was affected by the confrontations, he quickly insisted that he was fine. After several sessions, however, he unloaded on everyone in the group (including the supervisor) and let them know how angry he was. He declared that he was ready to leave. The group mood was again one of hesitancy, and members interacted very tentatively.

Group 2 members tended to compare themselves unfavorably to those in Group 1. During a combined session, people in Group 2 revealed the jealousy they had felt over the intensity and closeness that seemed to characterize Group 1.

On the next to last day, Group 2's level of trust remained minimal. The members showed great reluctance to be personal and to interact with one another. One of the supervisors (Jerry) again asked them to reflect on their level of trust and to assess the degree to which they were meeting their goals. He said to them: "This workshop is almost over. If today were the end, how would that be for you? If you aren't satisfied, what do you see that you can do to change the situation?" The members of Group 2 decided to have lunch together for the first time. The group sessions were scheduled to resume at 1 o'clock. When the group finally returned at 1:30, they were laughing and joking, obviously in a happy mood. They let the supervisor know what a wonderful time they had had at lunch and said they felt more comfortable and cohesive at lunch than they ever had in the group.

As a group we explored the dynamics of what was occurring. I (Marianne) confronted them by saying: "You say that talking at lunch was very easy and that you felt close to one another. You also say that when you come into this room, you feel stifled. What do you think is different?" Of course, the most obvious variable was the presence of the supervisor. As they began to open up, they initially lashed out at both supervisors. They perceived us as demanding too much, expecting them to be personal and academic at the same time, wanting them to perform, and demanding that they have problems (even if they didn't). They insisted that we had been unclear with them about our expectations. I listened to their grievances, attempting not to be defensive, which was not easy with the degree of hostility that was directed toward me. I did acknowledge that it was a difficult workshop and that indeed much was demanded of them, but I was not apologetic about my standards.

Finally, as a group, they admitted their envy over the intimacy the other group seemed to have, and they said they had tried to replicate this closeness at lunch. It was then that I challenged them again, as had Jerry before lunch, to reflect and begin to verbalize what they were rehearsing internally and what they were keeping from one another.

At the last session the members finally risked being more honest. They had taken our challenges seriously and had given thought to their behavior during the workshop. They were willing to take personal responsibility for their actions in the group, and there was no blaming. They accomplished more work in this final session because of their willingness to say what was on their minds. They learned in an experiential way that what they had not expressed during much of

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the week had kept them from having a productive group. Yet neither they nor we thought that their group had been a failure. They realized how their behavior had thwarted their progress as a group, and most were able to identify some of the ways in which their low level of risking had inhibited the trust level in their group. Because they were finally willing to talk in honest ways about their involvement in the group, they learned some important lessons about themselves as individuals as well as about the group process.

In the required follow-up papers, members of Group 2 wrote about their reactions during the week that they had never mentioned in the sessions. Had they chosen to express them at the time, we are quite certain their experience as a group and their individual experiences would have been very different. As supervisors, we experienced how draining it can be to work with a group that has a number of hidden agendas. Our experience has taught us the importance of making a commitment to face whatever may be going on, to bring hidden agendas to the surface, and, most of all, not to give up. As leaders we need to be careful not to indulge in our feelings of frustration and annoyance. It is not about us, but about how we can continue facilitating a group to a more productive level of work. Even though this group did not become cohesive, the members' willingness to process the group with us resulted in them learning important lessons about what had held them back as individuals and how this impasse at the transition stage had stalled their efforts to become a cohesive and working group.

Learning in Action

Barriers to Change

Contemplation is often the first stage of change. Even the thought of change is sometimes overwhelming and can stop a person before he or she has begun. Think of something you would like to change in yourself. For example, would you like to speak up more, or be less reactive when you feel angry? Once you have a specific goal in mind, create a collage. Using either a paper bag or a shoe box, decorate the outside of the bag or box with all of the images or words that symbolize the external barriers that you feel exist when you contemplate making this change. *External barriers* might be things such as a lack of support from others, limited resources, oppressive circumstances, or threat of negative reactions from others. Next, place images or words inside of the box or bag that symbolize the internal barriers that you engage in that keep you from reaching your desired change. *Internal barriers* to change are the beliefs we have about ourselves and the things we say that sabotage our successes along the way. They may also be behaviors that we engage in that stop us from moving in the direction of our desired change. Look through old magazines or newspapers to find images and words to use on your collage project, or draw or write your own images. Once you have completed the project, we encourage you to share it in your class or group.

Process Questions for Sharing

As you share your collage, consider discussing these ideas:

- What is the change you want to make, and how can you use the group to make this change?
- As you created your collage, what was the process of making it like for you? Did you struggle with it? What feelings came up for you, and what was your internal dialogue as you selected images and words and placed them on your collage?

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- What external barriers did you identify?
- What internal barriers did you identify?
- What parts of your collage are you drawn to most?

Tips for Listening and Giving Feedback

- Refrain from making too many comments or asking questions of the person who is sharing the collage. As an observer, your role is to listen without making interpretations about what you see.
- If you do relate to what the person is sharing, be cautious in your comments so you do not take the spotlight away from the person who is sharing.

LO11

Dealing With Transference and Countertransference

As we have emphasized, when you are leading groups, strive to recognize how your own unresolved personal issues can feed into problematic behaviors in members. This interplay involves transference and countertransference. **Transference** consists of the feelings clients project onto the counselor. These feelings usually have to do with relationships the clients have experienced in the past. When such feelings are attributed to the group counselor, the intensity of the feelings may have more to do with unfinished elements in a member's life than with the current situation. Transference originating from the client's conflicts is considered a healthy and normal part of therapy, and the therapist's job is to remain neutral. **Countertransference** occurs when counselors project their own unresolved conflicts onto the client. If countertransference is not properly managed by the leaders, it can be damaging to members. Rather than attempting to eliminate countertransference, the leaders should use their reactions in productive and therapeutic ways. Group practitioners who are psychodynamically oriented recognize the value of understanding the dynamics of both transference and countertransference. These key concepts are fundamental to furthering the work that occurs in a group.

A group context has the potential for multiple transferences. Members may project not only onto the leaders but also onto other members in the group. Depending on the kind of group being conducted, members may identify people who elicit feelings in them that are reminiscent of feelings they have for significant people in their lives, past or present. Again, depending on the purpose of the group, these feelings can be productively explored so members become aware of how they are keeping these old patterns functional in present relationships. The group itself provides an ideal place to become aware of certain patterns of psychological vulnerability. Members can gain insight into the ways their unresolved conflicts create certain patterns of dysfunctional behavior. By focusing on what is going on within a group session, the group provides a dynamic understanding of how people function in out-of-group situations.

Group members bring their life history and previous experiences with them to the group. Some members may hold beliefs about individuals from different cultural groups that interfere with their ability to connect with or to trust other group

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members or the group leader. For example, a man who identifies himself as gay may have experienced numerous judgments and rejections from the heterosexual community and therefore may have made an early decision that the heterosexual members are not going to accept him. One of the benefits of a therapeutic group is that members can explore how their past experiences are playing out in present interactions.

When group members appear to work very hard at getting the facilitator to reject them, it can be therapeutically useful to explore what potential gains they may be deriving from this self-defeating behavior. The transference reactions members develop toward the group leader and other members can bring out intense feelings in those who are the target of this transference. Handled properly in the therapeutic setting, members can experience and express feelings and reactions toward others in the group and discover how they are projecting outside situations onto the group. When these feelings are productively explored in the group, members often are better able to express their reactions appropriately.

Group leaders would do well to consider their countertransference as a possible cause of difficulties that develop in a group. Leaders can project their own problems and unfinished business onto "difficult members." Furthermore, some leaders have not recognized their own power and privilege and feel powerless when they are confronted by members who challenge their authority or competence. If leaders are not willing to deal with their own issues, how can they expect members to take the risks necessary for them to change? As you reflect on ways you may be emotionally triggered in groups you lead, examine your response to members that you perceive as being difficult. Remember, it is generally not useful to assume that your clients merely want to annoy you. Ask yourself these questions:

It is generally not useful to assume that your clients merely want to annoy you.

- How do I respond to the different forms of transference exhibited by members?
- What kind of transference tends to elicit my countertransference?
- Do I take the defensiveness of members in a personal way?
- Do I blame myself for not being skillful enough?
- Do I become combative with clients I view as problematic?
- Does the way in which I respond to problematic behaviors tend to increase or decrease defensiveness on the part of members?

As a group leader, you are faced with the task of dealing with the transference reactions members develop toward you, but the solution is often complex and depends on the circumstances under which the relationship develops. Do not quickly discount members' reactions to you as mere transference. Be willing to explore the possibility that members have genuine reactions to the way you have dealt with them. Do not believe uncritically whatever group members tell you, particularly initially. Be careful about quickly accepting some unrealistic attributions of group members. On the other hand, avoid being overly critical and discounting genuine positive feedback. All members who see a leader as helpful or wise do not have "transference disorders." Members can feel genuine affection and respect for group leaders. By the same token, just because participants become angry with you does not mean that they are transferring anger toward their parents

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onto you. They might well feel genuine anger and have negative reactions toward you personally largely because of certain behaviors you display. It takes courage on your part to acknowledge that you may have been insensitive to a client and are now receiving warranted reactions. However, members will frequently treat you as if you were a significant figure in their lives, and you get more reactions than you deserve. This is especially likely to be true if members exhibit intense feelings toward you when they have had very little contact with you. In short, all feelings that members direct toward the group leader should not be "analyzed" as transference to be "worked through" for the client's good. A useful guideline that we apply to ourselves is that if we hear a consistent pattern of feedback, then we seriously examine what is being told to us. When we see the validity of this feedback, we are likely to make some changes in our behavior.

The well-known Gestalt therapist Erving Polster (1995) avoids thinking in terms of transference phenomenon because he believes the concept of transference can have depersonalizing effects. Instead, Polster emphasizes the experience of real contact between client and therapist: "the contact experience is composed of telling, responding, suggesting, laughing, experimenting—everything that is actually going on. Adding to the power of this contactful engagement, however, is the symbolic component, which is represented by transference" (p. 190). For Polster, focusing on transference takes the therapist out of the here-and-now relationship by discounting what is actually going on in the therapeutic encounter. In addition, when therapists make interpretations of certain events, they may mistakenly discredit a client's own experience of those events. Thus the conceptualization of transference may result in diminished connectedness.

It is important to consider both members' reactions based on reality and those representing the symbolic component of transference. Even if you strongly suspect transference feelings, you would be discounting the person if you said, "I think you are projecting. This isn't about me." A less defensive response is, "Tell me more about how I affect you." This intervention elicits additional information about how the group member developed a set of reactions to you. The timing of making such a statement is crucial, and it is important to explore the member's reactions prior to suggesting any interpretation of the member's behavior.

When group members identify you as an object of transference, there is the potential for good therapeutic work. You can take on a symbolic role and allow the person to talk to you and work through unfinished business. Additionally, you and the person can engage in role reversal as a way to explore feelings and to gain insight. Assume that a member (Paul) becomes aware that he is behaving around you much as he does with his father. During a role play in which he is talking to you as his father, he says, "I don't feel important in your life. You're too busy and never have time for me. No matter what I do, it's never enough for you. I just don't know how to go about getting your approval." Because you do not know how Paul's father relates to him, you could ask Paul to take on the role of his father by responding as he imagines that his father would respond. After Paul has several interchanges in which he is both himself and his father, you will have a clearer sense of how he struggles with his father. With this information, you can help him work through his unresolved issues with both his father and with you. Through the process of his therapeutic work, Paul may be able to see you as the

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person you are rather than as the father with whom he is struggling. He might also gain awareness of the ways he talks to his father and how he transfers his feelings toward him to others in everyday life.

These are but a few illustrations of how transference problems can be worked through. The important elements are that these feelings first (1) be recognized and expressed and then (2) be interpreted and explored in a therapeutic way. Interpreting transference is a route to elucidating the group member's intrapsychic life (Wolitzky, 2011b). Interpretations can be offered in a collaborative manner to help group members make sense of their lives and to expand their consciousness. The group leader needs to use the member's reactions as a gauge in determining a member's readiness to make an interpretation. It is important that interpretations be appropriately timed because the group member will reject poorly timed interpretations given by leaders.

A more delicate issue is how the leader can best deal with feelings toward a group member. Even in the psychoanalytic tradition, which dictates that therapists spend years in analysis to understand and resolve blocked areas, countertransference is a potential problem. It can be a big problem for the beginning group leader. Some people are attracted to this profession because, on some level, they imagine that as a helper they will be respected, needed, admired, looked to as an expert, and even loved. Perhaps they have never experienced the acceptance and self-confidence in their ordinary lives that they feel while helping others. Such leaders may be using groups to fulfill needs that would otherwise go unmet.

The leader's countertransference reactions are inevitable because we all have unresolved conflicts, personal vulnerabilities, and unconscious "soft spots" that are activated through our professional work (Curtis & Hirsch, 2011; Hayes, Gelso, & Hummel, 2011; Wolitkzy, 2011a). Self-knowledge and supervision are central factors in learning to deal effectively with both members' transference and your own countertransference reactions. Your blind spots can easily hamper your ability to deal with various difficult behaviors displayed by members or with your old wounds that surface as you work with the members' pain. Ongoing supervision will enable you to accept responsibility for your reactions and at the same time prevent you from taking full responsibility for directions that specific members take. Meeting with your coleader to talk about how you are affected by certain members is an excellent way to get another's perspective on difficult situations.

Recognize that not all of your feelings toward members can be classified as countertransference. You may be operating under the misconception that you should remain objective and care for all members equally. Countertransference is indicated by exaggerated and persistent feelings that tend to recur with various clients in various groups. You can expect to enjoy some members more than others, yet all the members of your group deserve a chance to be respected and liked by you. It is important that you recognize your own feelings for what they are and that you avoid emotional entanglements that are not therapeutic.

The issue of power is relevant to understanding countertransference. As group members elevate the leader to the level of expert, perfect person, or demanding parent, members give away most of their power. A self-aware therapist who is interested primarily in clients' welfare will not encourage members to remain in an inferior position. The insecure leader who depends on clients' subordinate

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position for a sense of adequacy and power will tend to keep the group members powerless.

We do not want to convey the impression that it is inappropriate for you to meet some of your needs through your work. Nor are we suggesting that you should not feel powerful. In fact, if you are not meeting your needs through your work, we think you are in danger of losing your enthusiasm. But it is crucial that you do not exploit the members as a way of fulfilling yourself. The problem occurs when you put your own needs first or when you fail to be sensitive to the needs of group members.

Countertransference feelings are likely to develop in the romantic or sexual realm, particularly when a group member indicates a romantic interest in a group leader. Group leaders may never have felt desirable before assuming their professional role. Now that they do, there is the danger that they will depend on group members for this feedback. Through your training, you may have the opportunity to explore with a supervisor your feelings of attraction or repulsion toward certain members. If you are conducting groups independently and become aware of a pattern that indicates possible countertransference problems, seek consultation with another therapist to work through these problems.

Critical Incident

Overcorrecting for Fear of Overidentifying

1. Description of Incident

During the fifth session of an inpatient eating disorder group, Reem, the only Persian member in the group, shared her experiences as a minority woman in her master's program. Initially Reem spoke about feeling that she did not fit in with her classmates because of her ethnicity. She shared that she often felt she had to prove herself to her classmates and professors. The rest of the group began asking questions about her experiences, to which Reem responded, "None of you will every fully understand me because you are not Persian and don't know what it's like to be a minority." Another group member, Chelsea, became defensive and said that her best friend was Persian. Chelsea went on to share that her friend often talked about the cultural differences between them and that she felt as if her friend was overemphasizing their differences and sometimes saw her as "complaining too much." The discussion between Reem and Chelsea grew in intensity as the group members sat silent and anxiously watched the interchange.

The group leader felt caught off guard and didn't know how to best address the situation in the moment. The leader, who was also a Persian woman, was struggling to sort through her own internal conflict about how to intervene. The leader felt that Chelsea was invalidating Reem's experiences and shifting the focus onto herself. If the leader intervened on behalf of Reem, however, she feared it would appear that she was being "biased and fostering an unfair alliance with Reem." The leader was also worried that it might look as if she were "rescuing" Reem if she were to say anything to Chelsea.

2. Process Questions for Group Leaders

1. Have you ever felt immobilized as a group leader because you were concerned about how your intervention would be perceived?
2. Do you think it would have been appropriate for the leader to share some of her internal struggle about responding to Reem and Chelsea with the group? Why or why not?

continued

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3. What potential harm could have come from the leader sharing her own experience as a Persian woman or confirming what Reem was sharing?
4. What potential benefits might there have been for the leader identifying with Reem?
5. Could the leader have helped Chelsea see the impact of her comments without speaking for Reem or coming to her "rescue," as the leader feared it might appear?
6. What differences exist, if any, when a Caucasian leader or a leader of color intervenes using his or her cultural identity and experiences?

3. Clinical Reflections

The leader in this incident was so fearful of overidentifying with Reem that she temporarily missed seeing the potential benefits of having a group member and leader with cultural commonalities. Her internal struggle inhibited her from intervening therapeutically with the group. As a person of color, she has likely experienced some of the judgments and the need to seek the approval of others about which Reem had spoken. Ironically, the leader was holding her self back in ways similar to those of the member. What would it have been like for the leader to feel free enough to share her own struggle in the moment with the group members? Sharing her own process of not wanting to appear to be unfairly aligning with Reem or coming to her rescue may have freed the leader to make an intervention. She also could have given the group members more insight into what it feels like to be different from everyone else, validating Reem's experiences of feeling like "no one in the group would ever understand her." Most interventions leaders make will have an impact on members, and we often cannot predict the outcome of what we share in group. One potential downside of the leader not intervening in this incident is that Reem may have felt abandoned and even more misunderstood then before sharing her story. In an effort to keep the entire group comfortable, the leader missed an opportunity for a teachable moment.

4. Possible Interventions

1. The leader could model to the group members the benefits of editing aloud by sharing with them some of her own internal struggle. For example, she might say, "I want to talk about the ways in which I identify with Reem as a fellow Persian woman, but I find myself aware of how others might perceive this as me taking sides." Saying this potentially frees the leader to share her feelings while inviting members to comment and react to what she is saying. It then becomes a group conversation that is relevant to the cultural issues already shared by Reem and Chelsea. By sharing her own thoughts and feelings, the leader could help create trust and authenticity within the group.
2. The leader could share her internal struggle and ask all the members if they see any similarities to what the leader is feeling in the group and the experiences Reem shared about graduate school. Again this uses the leader's reactions but places the work on the group rather than on the leader.
3. The leader could use her personal experiences without stating directly that they are her own. The leader may have some understanding of what Reem is saying, and the leader can share some of that knowledge with the group without necessarily disclosing her own story. Depending on the theoretical orientation of the leader as well as her personal comfort level, this gives her options for using her identity and intervening.
4. The leader might ask group members to share a time when they felt left out of a group.
5. Ask Reem and Chelsea if they will participate in a role play. Reem could be asked to look at Chelsea and complete a few unfinished sentences: "One way I feel different from you is . . ." "A way I perceive you don't understand me is . . ." Reem could also make the rounds of all the members and complete the sentence, "One way I feel different from you is . . ."

   During this role-play exercise, group members could be asked to avoid responding and to simply take in what they hear Reem saying. If Reem stays focused on the theme of her difference, members gain information about how she sees herself as being different. It may also give Chelsea some insight about her friend outside of the group.
6. The leader may say, "I am having a reaction to Reem and Chelsea's discussion, and I am willing to share my reaction, but I want to invite other group members to share how they are experiencing Reem and Chelsea's discussion first." Inviting group members to share their thoughts first may facilitate the group's process of moving into the working stage.

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Coleader Issues at the Transition Stage

LO12

As you can see, the transition stage is a critical period in the history of the group. Depending on how conflict and resistance are handled, the group can take a turn for the better or for the worse. If you are working with a coleader, you can efficiently use the time you have for meeting before and after sessions to focus on your own reactions to what is occurring in the group. Here are a few problems that can develop between leaders at this time.

Negative Reactions Toward One Leader If members direct a challenge or express negative reactions toward a coleader, it is important to avoid either taking sides with your colleague in attacking clients or siding with the members in ganging up against the coleader. Instead, nondefensively (and as objectively as possible) continue your leadership by facilitating a constructive exploration of the situation. You might do this by asking the member who has a reaction to your coleader to speak directly to him or her. You could also invite your coleader to say *what* he or she is hearing and *how* he or she is being affected.

Challenges to Both Leaders Several members may direct criticism to both you and your coleader, saying, "You leaders expect us to be personal in here, but we don't know anything about you that's personal. You should be willing to talk about your problems if that's what you expect us to do." In such a case, difficulties can develop if one of you responds defensively while the other is willing to deal with this confrontation from the members. Ideally, both leaders should talk about the confrontation objectively. If not, this disagreement would surely be a vital topic to discuss in the coleaders' meeting outside of the group or during a supervision session. All such difficulties should not be reserved for a private discussion between coleaders. As much as possible, matters that pertain to what is happening during sessions should be discussed with the entire group.

Dealing With Problem Behaviors We have discussed a variety of difficult member behaviors that you and your coleader may have to confront. We want to caution against the tendency of coleaders to chronically discuss what such members are doing or not doing and never to explore how such behavior affects them as leaders. It is a mistake to dwell almost exclusively on strategies for "curing" problem members while ignoring your own personal reactions to such problematic behaviors.

Dealing With Countertransference It is not realistic to expect a leader to work equally effectively with every member. At times ineffectiveness results from countertransference reactions on the part of one of the leaders. For example, a male leader could have strong and irrational negative reactions to one of the women in the group. It may be that he is seeing his ex-wife in this member and responding to her in nontherapeutic ways because of his own unresolved issues

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over the divorce. When this situation occurs, the coleader can be therapeutic for both the member and the leader who is not being helpful. The colleague can intervene during the session itself as well as exploring these countertransference reactions with the other leader outside the session. Coleaders who are willing to be objective and honest with each other can have a positive impact through this process of mutual confrontation.

Journal Prompts

The following questions are meant to serve as prompts for members of a group during the transition stage. If you are conducting groups, you might find these useful for your group members to either discuss in group or journal about between sessions. In addition, think about your responses to these questions as either a real or imagined group member.

1. In what ways were you concerned or aware of being accepted or rejected by the group or individual members?
2. How did you test leaders or other members in the group to see if the group was safe for you?
3. In what ways did you play it safe or take risks in the group?
4. How did you express or navigate issues of control and power in the group?
5. What did you observe in leaders to determine whether they were trustworthy or not?

Points to Remember

Transition Stage of a Group

Transition Stage Characteristics

The transition phase of a group's development is marked by feelings of anxiety and defenses in the form of various behavior patterns.

- Members are concerned about what they will think of themselves if they increase their self-awareness and about others' acceptance or rejection of them.
- Members test the leader and other members to determine how safe the environment is.
- Members struggle between wanting to play it safe and wanting to risk getting involved.
- Control and power issues may emerge, or some members may experience conflict with others in the group.
- Members observe coleaders to determine whether they are trustworthy.
- Members learn how to express themselves so that others will listen to them.

Member Functions

A central role of members at this time is to recognize and deal with the many forms of resistance.

- Members recognize and express any persistent reactions; unexpressed feelings may contribute to a climate of distrust.
- Members respect their own defenses but work with them.

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- Members move from dependence to independence.
- Members learn how to confront others in a constructive manner so that they do not retreat into defensive postures.
- Members face and deal with reactions toward what is occurring in the group.
- Members work through conflicts rather than remaining silent or forming subgroups outside of the sessions.

Leader Functions

The major challenge facing leaders during the transition period is to provide a safe environment with clear boundaries. Another challenge is to intervene in the group in a sensitive and timely manner. The major task is to provide the encouragement and the challenge necessary for members to face and resolve conflicts and negative reactions that exist within the group and certain behaviors that stem from their defenses against anxiety. To meet this challenge, leaders have the following tasks:

- Teach members the value of recognizing and dealing fully with conflict situations.
- Assist members in recognizing their own patterns of defensiveness.
- Teach members to respect anxiety and defensive behavior and to work constructively with attempts at self-protection.
- Provide a model for members by dealing directly and tactfully with any challenges, either personal or professional.
- Avoid labeling members, but learn how to understand certain problematic behaviors.
- Assist members to become interdependent and independent.
- Encourage members to express reactions that pertain to here-and-now happenings in the sessions.

Exercises

Self-Assessment Scale for Group Members

This self-assessment is primarily aimed at helping group members evaluate their behavior in a group, but it also can be used by group leaders. Use this self-assessment scale to determine your strengths and weaknesses. Rate yourself as you see yourself at this time. If you have not had some type of group experience, rate yourself in terms of your behavior in the class you are in now. This exercise can help you determine the degree to which you may be a productive group member. If you identify specific problem areas, you can decide to work on them in your group.

After everyone has completed the inventory, the class should break into small groups, each person trying to join the people he or she knows best. Members of the groups should then assess one another's self-ratings.

Rate yourself from 1 to 5 on each of the following self-descriptions using this scale:

5 = This is almost always true of me.
4 = This is frequently true of me.
3 = This is sometimes true of me.
2 = This is rarely true of me.
1 = This is never true of me.

_____ **1.** I am readily able to trust others in a group.
_____ **2.** Others tend to trust me in a group situation.
_____ **3.** I disclose personal and meaningful material.
_____ **4.** I am willing to formulate specific goals and contracts.
_____ **5.** I am generally an active participant as opposed to an observer.

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_____ **6.** I am willing to openly express my feelings about and reactions to what is occurring within a group.

_____ **7.** I listen attentively to what others are saying, and I am able to discern more than the mere content of what is said.

_____ **8.** I do not give in to group pressure by doing or saying things that do not seem right to me.

_____ **9.** I am able to give direct and honest feedback to others, and I am open to receiving feedback about my behavior from others.

_____ **10.** I prepare myself for a given group by thinking of what I want from that experience and what I am willing to do to achieve my goals.

_____ **11.** I avoid monopolizing the group time.

_____ **12.** I avoid storytelling by describing what I am experiencing now.

_____ **13.** I avoid questioning others; instead I make direct statements to them.

_____ **14.** I am able to be supportive of others when it is appropriate without giving pseudosupport.

_____ **15.** I am able to confront others in a direct and caring manner by letting them know how I am affected by them.

Scenarios for Exploration

Many of the following exercises are ideally suited for small group interaction and discussion. Explore these questions from the vantage point of a group leader.

1. **Working With Members' Fears**. Assume that various members make these statements:
   - "I'm afraid of looking like a fool in the group."
   - "My greatest fear is that the other members will reject me."
   - "I'm afraid to look at myself because, if I do, I might discover that I'm empty."
   - "I'm reluctant to let others know who I really am because I've never done it before."

   With each of these statements, what might you say or do? Can you think of ways to work with members who express these fears?

2. **Moving Beyond Playing It Safe**. Imagine that you are leading a group that does not seem to want to get beyond the stage of "playing it safe." Members' disclosures are superficial, their risk-taking is minimal, and they display a variety of resistances. What might you do in such a situation? How do you imagine you would feel if you were leading such a group?
3. **Confronting Conflicts**. Assume that there is a good deal of conflict in a group you are leading. When you point this discord out to members and encourage them to deal with it, most of them tell you that they do not see any point in talking about the conflicts because "things won't change." What might be your response? How would you deal with a group that seemed to want to avoid facing and working with conflicts?
4. **Intervening With a Silent Member**. Betty is a group member who rarely speaks, even if encouraged to do so. What are your reactions to the following leader interventions?
   - Ignore her.
   - Ask others in the group how they react to her silence.
   - Remind her of her contract detailing her responsibility to participate.
   - Ask her what is keeping her from contributing.
   - Frequently attempt to draw her out.

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What interventions would you be likely to make?

5. **Redirecting a Questioner**. Larry has a style of asking many questions of fellow group members. You notice that his questioning has the effect of distracting members and interfering with their expression of feelings. What are some things you might say to him?
6. **Confronting a Member Who Is Storytelling**. Jessica has a habit of going into great detail in telling stories when she speaks. She typically focuses on details about others in her life, saying little about how she is affected by them. Eventually, another member says to her, "I'm really having trouble staying with you. I get bored and impatient with you when you go into such detail about others. I want to hear more about you and less about others." Jessica responds, "That really upsets me. I feel I've been risking a lot by telling you about problems in my life. Now I feel like not saying any more!" What interventions would you make at this point?
7. **Addressing Hostility of Group Members**. Imagine that you have been meeting with a group of middle school children whose parents are incarcerated. The members have begun to develop strong connections to you and to one another. Several of the members have opened up about some painful memories they have endured. One member of the group begins to lash out and "pick fights" with other members. He also uses racial slurs and makes homophobic comments when certain members speak up. Another member remarks, "This is stupid, I'm not coming to group anymore." Form small groups to consider these questions:
   - What are some of the dynamics you see occurring in the group?
   - What motivations might be behind these problem behaviors?
   - How would you respond to the racial slurs and homophobic comments made by one member, and what strategies would you use with the member who doesn't want to return?
   - How would you go about processing all of this within the group?
8. **Assessing Your Experiential Group**. If you are involved in an experiential group as part of your group class, this is a good time to assess any characteristics in your group that are typical of the transition stage. Assess your own level of participation in the group. What changes, if any, would you like to make as a member of your group? As a group, spend some time exploring these questions:
   - How is resistance being dealt with in the group?
   - How trusting is the climate?
   - If conflict is present, how is it being dealt with and how does this influence the group process?
   - Are any hidden agendas present?
   - What are you learning about what makes groups function effectively or what gets in the way of effective group interaction?

Questions for Discussion

Select one or more of these questions for exploration in a small group in the classroom:

- How do you understand the concept of resistance? What alternative concepts can you think of to explain what is often viewed as resistance?
- What member behavior would you find most difficult or challenging to deal with as a leader? Why? How do you think this member's behavior is likely to affect the way you lead the group?

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- How would you intervene if a member remained silent? What factors might explain the lack of participation by a group member?
- What would you say or do if a group member reminds you of someone in your life? How would you deal with this potential countertransference?
- How can you challenge members in a caring way without increasing their defensiveness?
- What cultural dimensions will you need to consider before confronting a member?

Guide to Groups in Action: Evolution and Challenges DVD and Workbook

Evolution of a Group

Here are some suggestions for making effective use of this chapter along with the transition stage segment of *Evolution of a Group*, the first program in *Groups in Action*.

1. **Characteristics of the Transition Stage**. In this chapter we identify some key characteristic of groups in transition. As you view the DVD, what characteristics do you observe unfolding in the group during the transition stage?
2. **Common Fears of Members**. Some common fears are typical during the transition stage. On the DVD members articulate some of their fears. What kind of fears might you have if you were in this type of group?
3. **Dealing With Conflict and Confrontation**. Although conflict often occurs during the transition stage, it can surface during the initial group session. On the DVD conflict occurs during both the initial and the ending stages. Did you learn anything about how to deal with conflict, regardless of when it occurs, from viewing the sessions? What are the possible consequences of ignoring conflict or dealing with it ineffectively? What guidelines would you want to teach members of your group about how to confront effectively?
4. **Using the Workbook**. If you are using the DVD and workbook, refer to Segment 3: Transition Stage of the workbook and complete all the exercises. Take the self-inventory and review the Coreys' commentary.

Challenges Facing Group Leaders

Here are some suggestions for making effective use of this chapter along with the first segment of *Challenges Facing Group Leaders*, the second program in *Groups in Action*.

1. **Characteristics of the Transition Stage**. As you view this second program, what characteristics do you observe in this group that are typical of the transition stage?
2. **Challenges During the Transition Stage**. As coleaders, we see our task as intervening in a way that makes the room safe and provides a climate whereby members can talk about their hesitations. What is the importance of carefully working with whatever members bring to a group regarding their fears, concerns, or

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reservations? How is this transitional work essential if you hope to help a group move to a deeper level of interpersonal interaction? From reading this chapter and viewing the DVD, what are you learning about the leader's task during the transition stage in a group?

3. **Problem Behaviors and Difficult Group Members**. As you watch and study Segment 1, notice signs of problematic behaviors on the part of members. Also notice signs of defensiveness and reluctance and how members express and work with their resistance. The themes that are enacted in segment one of the DVD are illustrative of challenges that group leaders typically encounter in many different groups. These themes include the following:

   - Checking in: What was it like to return to group?
   - The leaders let me down.
   - I'm not feeling safe in here.
   - I didn't want to come back to group.
   - I'm in this group against my will.
   - Emotions make me uncomfortable.
   - I'm self-conscious about my accent.
   - I want the leaders to disclose more.
   - I learn a lot by being quiet.
   - Silence serves a function.
   - I feel pressured to disclose.
   - What's wrong with helping others?
   - Can't we stop all this conflict?
   - I feel weak when I show feelings.
   - Checking out: What are each of you taking from this session?

   In small groups, explore these questions: What kind of difficult group member would present the greatest challenge to you? Do you have any ideas about why a certain problematic member might "trigger" you more than others? What do you see the coleaders doing when members display behaviors that could be seen as problematic? What lessons are you learning about how to work therapeutically with resistance of group members? How can you apply the discussion of reframing resistance in this chapter to better understand what is going on in the DVD?

4. **Challenging Members and Creating Linkages**. Establishing trust is especially important as members identify some of the ways they typically protect themselves and express how they are holding back. What are you learning about the critical balance between support and confrontation? As you watch the first segment, how are members being challenged? How do they respond? As coleaders, we are consistently asking members to say more about what they are thinking and feeling as it pertains to being in the group. We also look for opportunities for members to establish linkages with one another and to talk to each other directly in the group. What are you learning about how to encourage members to express themselves more fully?

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5. **Using the Workbook**. If you are using the DVD and workbook, refer to Segment 1: Challenges of Dealing With Difficult Behaviors in Group of the workbook and write your comments in the "Reflection and Responses" section. Review the Coreys' reflections on the session and their commentary.

MindTap for Counseling

Additional resources can be found on CengageBrain.com and by logging into the MindTap course created by your professor. There you will find a variety of study tools and useful resources that include quizzes, videos, interactive exercises, and more.

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